Danger Close! Can the church rescue America?

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DANGER CLOSE! CAN THE CHURCH RESCUE AMERICA?

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Introduction

GRAVE DANGER

"Prepare to meet your God, O Israel" (Amos 4:12)

Col. Jessup: "I ordered Col. Markusen to have Santiago transferred off the base immediately"

Lt. Kaffee: "Why?"

Col. Jessup: "I felt his life might be in danger once word of the letter got out."

Lt. Kaffee: "Grave danger?"

Col. Jessup: "Is there another kind?"

The dialogue you have just read comes from the movie, "A Few Good Men", which was released in 1992. Lt. Kaffee, played by Tom Cruise, is the defense attorney for two marines accused of murdering a fellow marine. Col. Jessup, played by Jack Nicholson, is the commanding officer of the marine detachment at Guantanamo Bay, Cuba and Lt. Kaffee has him on the witness stand and is trying to make Col. Jessup admit that he gave the order that resulted in the death of the marine. (It is certainly worth watching.) While this movie is about the trial of these 2 marines, and Lt. Kaffee's efforts to get to the truth, the point of the above dialogue is that if there is danger, it is always grave danger.

I believe that America is in danger of being judged by God, and if Col. Jessup is right, we are in grave danger.

Another movie, "Tears of the Sun", starring Bruce Willis, has a scene at the end which also helps communicate the situation I believe our nation faces. Willis is a Lieutenant commanding a Seal Team that is extracting an American citizen from a war-torn African nation. A rebel force is closing in on them and the Seals are very close to being wiped out. They call for support from 2 Navy jets which come to their aid by dropping ordinance on the enemy at just the right time. As the jets draw near to bomb the enemy Willis has one of his men "pop smoke" to identify their position and then he radios the pilots, "danger close." This means that he wants the bombs dropped so close to the Seal's position that it will be dangerous for the Seals as well as the enemy. He is actually asking the pilots to put his team in a very dangerous situation.

I believe that America is in a "Danger Close" situation now and that that danger is very grave. It is not because we are asking for protection, rather we are asking for God's judgement and there is nothing more dangerous than the judgement of God. You might be thinking that God doesn't do that kind of thing any more, or certainly no one would ask for God's judgement. Indeed, most Americans, even Bible-believing Christians, would laugh at such a notion. We may not be verbally asking God to judge us, but the leadership of our country by the laws they pass and the judgements they make are telling God that they don't care what he thinks about anything. We now decide what is right and wrong. We're not angry at God; rather, in spite of all the "God-talk" we have made God completely irrelevant. And we have the audacity to suppose that he cannot or will not do anything about it. We've demonstrated total disdain and lack of respect for God and his commands.

I want us to imagine how God must think after all he has done for this country. We're truly a blessed nation, and for the last several decades we've told the One who has been so generous to us that we just don't give a rip what he thinks about anything. Oh, we're certainly willing to go to him when things go bad (a terrorist attack, or a life-threating in-

jury to a pro football player); but when it comes to ordering our lives in accordance with what he says is best, we aren't interested. We actually believe we know better than our creator how life is supposed to work. The arrogance of our culture is reflected in the laws our government has passed and some of the rulings of the highest court in the land. This should cause us all to be nervous.

The verse I placed at the beginning of this chapter comes from the prophet Amos who was telling Israel that God had been trying over and over to get their attention so they could repent and serve God instead of themselves. It is a very scary verse because Amos is saying that now it is too late and you are about to meet God and it will be extremely unpleasant. His judgment would mean total devastation to the nation of Israel. His judgement on us would mean an end to our society as we know it—our freedoms, our way of life, and our prosperity. The judgment of God against nations revealed in the Bible is very ugly, and I don't want to see our country go through something like that.

It may seem like I believe there is no hope for America, but actually I believe there is great hope. Jesus said that the gates of Hell will not be able to prevail against his church. (Matthew 16:18) This means that Satan's kingdom cannot withstand the church. While I believe that the church in America needs reformation, it is still Jesus' church and when we trust him and become the church he has called us to be, we can build up the wall and stand in the gap so God does not have to judge our country. (Ezekiel 22:30)

Whether or not God is going to judge us only he knows. I am certainly not a prophet like the Old Testament prophets who were told directly by God what to say to people so I am not saying that God told me this. What I am saying is that as I read and study Scripture and see the things that really upset God we certainly deserve God's judgement and therefore we could very well experience it. The first half of this book is

why I believe we deserve judgement. The second half is what the church needs to change in order prevent God from judging us. If you continue to read please prayerfully consider what God would have you and the church you are part of do.

1

Playing with Fire

They have forsaken the Lord;

they have spurned the Holy One of Israel

and turned their backs on him.

Isaiah 1:4

My impression of the average American's view of God is that he's a really loving God who wants our lives to be really great. Many of these people think they know God's job description. Who does he report to? *Us.* What are his responsibilities? *Make our life work according to our agenda and our ideas about what's right and what's wrong.* And should God have the audacity to fail at this, he's in big trouble. Why, we'll have nothing to do with him! We'll show him who's boss!

Or maybe our mindset is that God is out there, but he's not really involved in this world; he just watches and allows us to do our own thing, and he doesn't really care what we do, as long as we're happy. Or we think that God is love (and only love), and he just wants us to feel good and be happy; if a bad thing happens to us, it's because God didn't know it was coming, so it's not his fault.

A cursory examination of the cross of Jesus Christ reveals an entirely different picture of the God of the universe. Yes, the cross certainly reveals that God is love (1 John 4:10; John 3:16). There has never been and never will be a greater act of love than the cross. That God would send his Son to die a horrible death so our sins could be forgiven, so we could live in God's heaven forever—this is a love beyond all human comprehension. The problem is that we tend to ignore why God had to

send his Son to die. God is also just (Deuteronomy 32:4; Isaiah 45:19), and his justice demands that sin be punished.

Romans 3:25-26 makes it clear that the cross is as much about justice as it is about God's love. Both the 1 John passage and the Romans passage use a word that means God's wrath against our sin has been removed through the death of Christ. The whole idea behind "salvation" is that someone is in need of rescuing because they're unable to help themselves. Think of a drowning person. Unless the lifeguard dives in and saves them, they will die. Or think of someone utterly lost in the wilderness. Unless rescue teams find them and save them, they will die.

So it is with the human race. Our sin offends the righteous and holy God of the universe, and because he is righteous and just, he must punish us. "The wrath of God is a terrible reality, and the evil-doer has a frightful prospect before him."[1] Jesus is God's rescue team and lifeguard to save us from a horrible fate in hell. What's amazing is that this person we've offended takes it upon himself to make it possible for us to be forgiven.

I truly believe that the more we understand how awful our sin is to God, the more we will grasp and be amazed at his love. So the cross shows us not only that we are loved; it shows us also that God is really ticked off at sin.

One more thing the cross of Christ demonstrates is that God is fully involved in what's going on in this world, and he understands our predicament much better than we think. He also cares deeply about us. The cross shows that God actually knows what he's doing, even when we think that so much that's happening in our life is bad and wrong. The disciples' whole world was shattered by the crucifixion, even though Jesus had been telling them over and over that it was going to happen, and that he would then rise from the dead. They didn't understand. The resurrection fixed all of that, but those were a tough three days for all his followers. The cross tells us that even when we don't un-

derstand why some things are happening, God cares deeply for us, and he actually does know what's going on and what he's doing.

There's another truth about God we tend to ignore—it's the truth that he's the God of history, and he acts in history in accordance with his holy, righteous, and loving character. We're such an individualized society that we often forget that God deals with groups of people too. A casual reading of the Old Testament reveals that God raises up nations and tears down nations to accomplish his purposes.

The best example of this is the nation of Israel. God created this nation, this people group, so he could bring the Messiah into the world (Genesis 12:3; 49:10; 2 Samuel 7:12-16). The Old Testament is basically the story of God working in and through this nation to bring Jesus into the world.

But Israel isn't the only nation we see God dealing with in the Old Testament. God deals also with the Egyptians, Babylonians, Assyrians, Persians, and all the other nations in the regions around Israel. A cursory reading of both the major and minor prophets reveals God raising up nations to accomplish his purposes regarding Israel. Sadly, they were often raised up to punish Israel for Israel's rebellion against God. God would then turn around and punish these nations because they became proud and went too far and were too brutal when they conquered Israel.

Ezekiel 21 is a particularly brutal chapter that describes God punishing Israel through the Babylonians. Ezekiel 22 goes on to describe the things God has against his own people, and how they deserved the judgment that's certainly coming. One of the constant refrains in the book of Ezekiel is this: "Then they will know that I am the Lord." This is regularly used in the context of judgment. It's clear that God's glory and character is revealed not just in blessing people but also in judging them.

That fact should frighten us. Israel was judged and punished for ignoring the clear commands of God, and the nations were generally punished for their pride and arrogance in addition to how they treated Israel. The God of the universe, who holds our very breath in his hands, is certainly loving, merciful, and kind, but push him too far—and we better look out.

This truth was forcefully brought home to me many years ago when I preached through the book of Amos in the Old Testament. Amos was a simple farmer or rancher from the Southern Kingdom of Judah (1:1; 7:14-15), who was sent by God to tell the Northern Kingdom of Israel that God was fed up, and they were about to be destroyed. The reason this should be frightening to America is that when Amos was speaking to God's people, their combined nations were stronger and richer than they had been since the days of Solomon. In his *History of Israel*, John Bright says,

> By the mid-eighth century the dimensions of Israel and Judah together lacked but little of being as great as those of the empire of Solomon.... This resulted in a prosperity such as no living Israelite could remember.

Besides being strong militarily and economically, Israel and Judah were also very religious, though not in the best way. Again, Dr. Bright:

> Though the great shrines of Israel were busy, thronged with worshipers, and lavishly supported (Amos 4:11-14), it is evident that Yahwism in pure form was no longer maintained.

The outward appearance of prosperity and strength and faith in God hid a morally corrupt inside—and God finally had enough. These people didn't realize it, but they had less than forty years before they would cease to exist as a nation. They were utterly destroyed by the Assyrian

Empire, and what few of them were left were scattered throughout the world.

One of the most poignant passages in Amos occurs in chapter 4. God had done many things to try and get Israel's attention so they would change their ways and he wouldn't have to judge them, but they refused to listen. Five times in Amos 4 we read, "Yet you have not returned to me, declares the Lord." Over and over God has tried to make them see that they need to repent and turn to him. He has sent prophets and caused natural disasters, yet they refuse to pay attention.

Then comes what to me is one of the scariest verses in the Bible: "Therefore this is what I will do to you, Israel, and because I will do this to you, Israel, prepare to meet your God" (4:12).

Amos goes on to rebuke Israel's complacency (6:1), pride (6:8), religious hypocrisy (5:21-23), and social injustices—especially the rich taking advantage of the poor (5:11-12; 8:4-6). And they were doing all this while actually believing God was on their side. Little did they know that God stood against them and was about to destroy them.

I don't see a lot of difference between Israel of the eighth century B.C. and America today. I'm certainly no prophet like Amos, so I'm not saying I know that God is about to judge America. But the similarities are scary.

Here is my overall concern: Too many Americans fail to realize that the holy God of the universe, who most of us would say has blessed America, must be very upset by what he sees happening in our country. The leadership of our nation stands against what God says is right and champions what God says is wrong. Many of our leaders profess to be good Christian people, very much like the people Amos speaks God's judgment to. No person or nation is perfect, but the Bible is clear that certain things really upset God.

I believe there are four things that our country is doing that especially push all the wrong buttons for God. And when we play with fire, we eventually get burned.

2

Does God's Opinion on Divorce Matter?

"I hate divorce," says the Lord, the God of Israel,

"and him who covers his garment with wrong,"

says the Lord of hosts.

"So take heed to your spirit,

that you do not deal treacherously."

Malachi 2:16 nasb

Ronald Reagan signed into California law no-fault divorce in 1969. No-fault divorce means that a person or persons can obtain a divorce without proving fault. All fifty states now have some form of no-fault divorce on the books. When Governor Reagan signed this law he wanted "to eliminate the strife and deception often associated with the legal regime of fault-based divorce.... He later admitted it was one of the biggest mistakes of his political life."[2] The essence of no-fault divorce is that one spouse can end their marriage for any reason they choose—even "I just don't want to be married anymore." Their spouse has no recourse.

The purpose of this book is not to examine the social consequences of divorce or the statistics of divorce, so I won't delve into those areas; just doing an internet search of "no-fault divorce" yields anyone a vast trove of information. My purpose here is rather to examine how God feels about no-fault divorce.

The biblical teaching on divorce is certainly a greatly debated subject and I'm not going to even attempt to engage that subject here. One thing everyone who takes the Bible seriously agrees on is that God doesn't like divorce even a little bit. But does he actually hate it? Malachi 2:16 would seem to indicate that he does. There's a problem

though with the translation of the Hebrew of this verse. I've quoted from the nasb, which agrees with the kjv and rsv. The niv translates it as, "The man who hates and divorces his wife, says the Lord, the God of Israel, does violence to the one he should protect, says the Lord Almighty." I'll leave it to the language scholars to debate and decide this issue, because I think it's obvious from the rest of the Bible that God is strongly against divorce.

Marriage is a highly important institution to God. He's actually the one who invented it and defined it (Genesis 2). Marriage is regularly used in the Old Testament to represent God's covenant relationship to the Jewish people. God is the faithful husband who is regularly hurt by his unfaithful wife, Israel. Of course, God never gives up on Israel and remains faithful to his promises to her. The New Testament also uses marriage to illustrate the relationship between Christ and his church (Ephesians 5). It's unthinkable that God would be unfaithful either to Israel or the church (book of Hosea; Romans 3:3-4).

It's helpful to understand that when the Bible says God hates something or someone, this is not at all like human hate, which is emotionally charged and irrational. God's hatred is his strong, firm, and settled opposition to something or someone.

So when Jesus says (in Matthew 19:6), "Therefore what God has joined together, let no one separate," he's communicating that God takes marriage seriously, and anyone who doesn't is not smart. One may ask—as the Pharisees did (in 19:7)— "What about Deuteronomy 24:1-4?" Jesus' answer to them is instructive: "Moses permitted you to divorce your wives because your hearts were hard. But it was not this way from the beginning" (19:8). God understands better than anyone the ramifications of sin, and he clearly recognizes that due to the hardness of the human heart there will be times when divorce is actually necessary. However, that's never what God intends for marriage, so we better

take marriage vows seriously. The disciples totally understood what Jesus was saying, as shown by their comment in response: "It is better not to marry" (19:10).

How does all of this relate to America? The duly elected governments of all fifty states of this great country have decided that marriage doesn't really matter. In fact, as we'll see later in this book, the highest court in the land had the audacity to tell God that his understanding of marriage—which God invented, by the way—is wrong. We've given "moral legitimacy to the dissolution of marriages."[3] No-fault divorce not only has devastating social consequences (as a casual reading of the literature on this subject shows), but it's offensive to God.

Divorce is certainly not the unforgiveable sin, and the church has typically not done a good job of dealing with divorced people, but in this book, that's not the issue in focus. It's not so much that many individuals in our country have elected to divorce; it's that leaders in all fifty states—the people who are supposed to stand up for what is right—have decided we can ignore the clear teaching of Jesus and make divorce easy.

The context of Malachi 2 teaches us that God has a tendency to remove his blessing from nations that do such things.

3

Does God's Opinion on Sex Matter?

They not only continue to do these very things

but also approve of those who practice them.

Romans 1:32

In the Supreme Court's *Obergefell v. Hodges* decision of June 26, 2015, the highest court in our land decided that what God thinks about marriage is irrelevant, and that our ever changing culture is the final arbiter on what marriage is.

A recent Gallup poll[4] reports that 71 percent of Americans support gay marriage. This is up from 27 percent in 1996, the first year Gallup began asking about this. The only group opposed to same-sex marriage is weekly church attenders, and even in this group, 40 percent approve of same-sex marriage.

It must not be enough that we decide what marriage is. We're now trying to redefine our gender. We're born biologically as either a man or a woman, but so what? We can all be whatever gender we feel like. We can even change back and forth, and if we want to make the change permanent, we can take drugs and eventually have surgery. Like the LGBTQ people, the "transgenders" are not just asking for equal treatment under the law; they're demanding that we approve of and promote their lifestyle.

I certainly believe we should have a great deal of compassion for those struggling with gender dysphoria, and give them the help they need to deal with that issue. I also realize that a number of people struggle with same-sex attraction, but that doesn't mean it's good for them to give in to those feelings and live a homosexual lifestyle.

It's interesting that the same people who talk about the scientific certainty of climate change will ignore the even greater scientific certainty about sex. This would certainly be quite all right—except that there's a God who lets us know that certain things are an abomination to him.

The Bible is clear—despite what many from the LGBTQ community say—that homosexual sex is wrong, and not just wrong but very wrong. I won't spend a lot of time discussing and refuting the arguments from those who say the Bible doesn't actually condemn homosexual relationships. Their confusion has been ably exposed by Robert A. J. Gagnon in his excellent book *The Bible and Homosexual Practice: Text and Hermeneutics*, where he writes,

> First, there is clear, strong, and credible evidence that the Bible unequivocally defines same-sex intercourse as sin. Second, there exist no valid hermeneutical arguments, derived from either general principles of biblical interpretation or contemporary scientific knowledge and experience, for overriding the Bible's authority on this matter. In sum, the Bible presents the anatomical, sexual, and procreative complementarity of male and female as clear and convincing proof of God's will for sexual unions. Even those who do not accept the revelatory authority of Scripture should be able to perceive the divine will through the visible testimony of the structure of creation. Thus same-sex intercourse constitutes an inexcusable rebellion against the intentional design of the created order.[5] (p. 37)

I should point out here that to God, some sins are actually worse than others—and should therefore be considered worse by us as well. In too many conversations I've heard Christians say, "Sin is sin; it's all equal in God's eyes." It's certainly true that all sin, whether large or small, reveals that our very nature is corrupt, and that we stand condemned before the holy God of the universe not because of any particular sin but because we're sinners by nature. However, the Bible is clear that some sins are worse than others. When Jesus stood before Pilate, he said, "You

would have no power over me if it were not given to you from above. Therefore, the one who handed me over to you is guilty of a greater sin" (John 19:11). Jesus, in his arrest and trial, makes clear that there are greater and lesser sins. The Old Testament also clearly demonstrates that all sins are not equal in God's eyes—as seen by the different degrees and types of punishment assigned to them.

Same-sex intercourse is one of the worst of sins, as far as God is concerned. Dr. Gagnon's discussion of Leviticus 18:22[6] is very helpful on this point. Same-sex intercourse is particularly bad because it's a violation of the natural order of things (Romans 1:26-27), the way God created things to work. Those involved in same-sex intercourse are telling God, "We don't care what you think about sex; we're going to do whatever we feel like doing, and you, God, can take a hike." In other words what God says is right just doesn't matter. This should make us nervous in light of what happened to Sodom and Gomorrah. (Again, Dr. Gagnon's book is excellent on this.[7])

We live in a culture that not only doesn't care what God thinks about same-sex intercourse, but also goes to great lengths to make sure it's actually seen as a *good* thing. The response by our Congress to the Supreme Court's landmark *Dobbs* abortion decision was to pass the Respect for Marriage Act. This law was quickly put together and passed in order to prevent the Supreme Court from revisiting the *Obergefell* decision. Supposedly they feared that the conservative Supreme Court that had just overturned *Roe* would now overturn same-sex marriage and maybe even interracial marriage. The arrogance of our lawmakers to call this bill the Respect of Marriage Act is tragic. God—not the United States Congress—defines marriage. This bill should be called the Disrespect for God Act.

4

Do We Hear What God Hears?

What have you done? Listen!

Your brother's blood cries out to me from the ground.

Genesis 4:10

Abortion's prevalence in America is another big reason that we should be concerned.

I'm quite sure that some of you reading this have either had an abortion or have enabled and even encouraged someone to have an abortion. Abortion is not the unforgiveable sin. I would remind you of Isaiah 1:18— "Come now, let us settle the matter, says the Lord. Though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow; though they are red as crimson, they shall be like wool." This is referring to the worst kind of violent sins we could imagine. Add to this Romans 8:1-2— "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus, because through Christ Jesus the law of the Spirit who gives life has set you free from the law of sin and death." All who have trusted the work of Christ on the cross and his resurrection for the forgiveness of sin are completely okay with God. Your sins have been wiped away—even the sin of abortion.

I urge you to claim the promise of these verses and allow Christ to heal your heart. I also believe that your aborted child is now with God in heaven, and that the day is coming when you'll be reunited, and your child will give you a great big hug. This is not just some pie-in-the-sky wishful thinking. In 2 Samuel 11–12, we're told the story of David and Bathsheba, and how the child born from their adulterous relationship died. Chapter 12 reveals that David's friends were worried he might kill himself when he found out the baby had died (12:15-18). Quite

to the contrary—and to everyone's great surprise—David seemed calm and unmoved. People were shocked and wondered how he could act this way. David's explanation was simple: "Can I bring him back again? *I will go to him*, but he will not return to me" (12:23). Only someone who's certain of the resurrection from the dead can speak and act like this.

The parallels to abortion are interesting. David's child died because of David and Bathsheba's sin—likewise with abortion, children die because of their parents' sin; the babies don't choose to kill themselves. However, Christ died for the parents' sin; in Christ, you can and should have complete confidence that God has made everything okay.

David was confident that he would be reunited with the son who had died because of David's sin. Your aborted child has forgiven you just as God has, and when you arrive in heaven, he or she will welcome you with open arms.

The Supreme Court's *Dobbs* decision in 2022 regarding abortion was encouraging, but I don't think it has even come close to fixing the problem we have with God over this issue. It certainly helps, but I fear we have a long way to go. The infamous *Roe v. Wade* decision of 1973, along with *Doe v. Bolton*, paved the way for the brutal murders of innocent children up to the moment of birth, all in the name of a woman's right to choose. The number of abortions since 1973 is staggering—more than 63 million. There was actually a steady decline in the annual rate of abortions since the high of 1.6 million in 1990, to a low of about 860,000 in 2017. Since then, there has been a steady increase to around 1.1 million per year. Medication abortions (those using the drugs mifepristone and misoprostol) now account for more than half of all abortions, 65% in 2023. We are now in the place where a woman can commit murder in the privacy of her home and most Americans are OK with it.

Most states still allow abortion until fetal viability, which is around twenty-two to twenty-five weeks, depending on who one talks to. A few states still allow abortion at any stage of the pregnancy. A few have banned abortion altogether unless the life of the mother is threatened, or in the case of rape or incest. This situation is certainly much better than it has been, but we're still killing babies. The Pew Research Center in 2022 published a report which gave the results of a poll they took after the *Dobbs* decision; the report was titled, "Majority of Public Disapproves of Supreme Court's Decision to Overturn *Roe v. Wade*." This report stated that 62 percent of Americans believe abortion should be legal in all or most circumstances. They also reported that 57 percent of Americans opposed the court's decision. How much longer can God tolerate a country that claims to be blessed by God—a nation that sings "God Bless America" and asks him to "stand beside her and guide her"—and yet has no intention of following him.

I say this because the Bible is clear that innocent bloodshed "cries out to God from the ground" (Genesis 4:10). This comes from the story of Cain and Abel. Cain killed his bother Abel, and when God confronted Cain about this, Cain denied any knowledge of Abel's whereabouts. Then God said to Cain, "What have you done? Listen! Your brother's blood cries out to me from the ground." Numbers 35:33 likewise speaks of the land becoming defiled through bloodshed, and Leviticus 18:24-25 speaks of God kicking out the people who defile it in this and other ways.

Another interesting text is Deuteronomy 21:1-9. In this passage, the Jews are told how to handle a situation in which a murdered person is found but there is no way of determining who the killer is. The town closest to the body was to offer a sacrifice, and the elders of that community were to wash their hands over the sacrifice while declaring that they had no knowledge of how this person was killed. "Then the bloodshed will be atoned for, and you will have purged from yourselves the

guilt of shedding innocent blood" (Deuteronomy 21:8-9). God obviously doesn't take lightly the shedding of innocent blood.

Jesus teaches us that the very hairs on our heads are numbered, and that not a sparrow falls to the ground without God's knowledge. Somehow I think an innocent baby is far more important than either hair or sparrows. And I wonder just how much longer God can tolerate listening to the cries of 63 million little voices.

5

Playing God Is Dangerous

Woe to those who call evil good and good evil,

who put darkness for light and light for darkness,

who put bitter for sweet and sweet for bitter.

Isaiah 5:20

I've been attempting to make the case that America is in grave danger of God's righteous judgment because we've decided that God's views about divorce, life, and sex not only do not matter; they are wrong. The Bible is clear that these are big issues with God, but we just don't care. That's dangerous—not just because these three things matter so much to God, but because our disregard of them demonstrates an attitude of pride and arrogance that God finds extremely offensive.

I believe that God has raised up and especially blessed this country. This doesn't mean that I think we ever were a true "Christian" nation, but our founders certainly held traditional Judeo-Christian values which became the foundation of our great nation. Our greatness stems not from our capabilities but from God's blessing because of the moral and philosophical foundation of our nation. Our founders were very much aware that there is a holy God out there to whom everyone will eventually have to answer. Looking back at the history of our country, we can see God's hand of blessing in so many different areas of our national life. I certainly don't think we were without sin throughout our history, but no nation or person (except Jesus) has ever accomplished that. I'm not a great historian or sociologist, but it seems to me that since World War II, we've become prideful and arrogant as a country.

Japanese Admiral Isoroku Yamamoto, who planned the attack on Pearl Harbor, would reportedly write in his diary, "I fear that all we have done is to awaken a sleeping giant and fill him with a terrible resolve." Admiral Yamamoto's statement could not have been more true. World War II created an industrial and military superpower unlike anything the world had ever seen. We became the most powerful and greatest nation on the planet, and remained in that position for several decades. Everyone has wanted to come to America, the land of the free and the home of the brave—America, the land of opportunity.

I fear that our greatness and prosperity have gone to our head. We've become much like King Nebuchadnezzar—who pridefully said of himself, as he looked out over his capital, "Is not this the great Babylon I have built as the royal residence, by my mighty power and for the glory of my majesty?" (Daniel 4:30). We act as if we have become great because of our own wisdom and power. Oh, we give lip service to God, with things like "one nation under God" in the Pledge of Allegiance, or the motto "In God we trust" on our coins and paper currency. And when bad things happen (such as the 9/11 terrorist attacks), we even ask God for help at the time, but it seems to me it's only lip service. Jesus said, "These people honor me with their lips, but their hearts are far from me" (Matthew 15:8).

Pride and arrogance are especially offensive to God. Proverbs 6:16-19 lists seven things "that the Lord hates," and the first item on the list is "haughty eyes." In everyday language, we seldom use that word *haughty*; the idea behind it is arrogance and superiority and looking down on someone or something. The first thing God hates is pride and arrogance. Lying and murder are on the list too, but not first. Maybe that should tell us something.

There are several Scripture verses that communicate God's attitude toward prideful people. In the book of Proverbs, the voice of wisdom calls out,

> To fear the Lord is to hate evil; I hate pride and arrogance, evil behavior and perverse speech (Proverbs 8:13).

Note how "evil behavior" (such as divorce, abortion, homosexuality) is associated here with pride and arrogance.

Notice especially that God says prideful people will be humbled:

> When pride comes, then comes disgrace, but with humility comes wisdom. (Proverbs 11:2)

> The Lord detests all the proud of heart. Be sure of this: They will not go unpunished. (Proverbs 16:5)

> Pride goes before destruction, a haughty spirit before a fall. (Proverbs 16:18)

> The eyes of the arrogant will be humbled and human pride brought low; the Lord alone will be exalted in that day. (Isaiah 2:11)

God speaks also against prideful nations and rulers:

> When the Lord has finished all his work against Mount Zion and Jerusalem, he will say, "I will punish the king of Assyria for the willful pride of his heart and the haughty look in his eyes." (Isaiah 10:12)

> Babylon, the jewel of kingdoms, the pride and glory of the Babylonians, will be overthrown by God like Sodom and Gomorrah. (Isaiah 13:19)

> We have heard of Moab's pride—how great is her arrogance!—of her conceit, her pride, and her insolence; but her boasts are empty. (Isaiah 16:6)

> The terror you inspire and the pride of your heart have deceived you, you who live in the clefts of the rocks, who occupy the heights of the hill. Though you build your nest as high as the eagle's, from there I will bring you down, declares the Lord. (Jeremiah 49:16)

> The Sovereign Lord has sworn by himself— the Lord God Almighty declares: I abhor the pride of Jacob and detest his fortresses; I will deliver up the city and everything in it. (Amos 6:8)

No matter how strong a nation's defenses are, they cannot stand against God when he judges them for their pride. Peter sums up God's overall attitude toward prideful people and nations by quoting Proverbs 3:34— "God opposes the proud but shows favor to the humble" (1 Peter 5:5). The God of the universe is not someone we want against us.

We live in a culture which has arrogantly decided that what God calls bad is in reality good, and what God calls good is actually bad. We do this as we sing "God Bless America," "America the Beautiful," or "God Bless the USA." We need to review the first five chapters of the book of Isaiah, where the prophet gives an overview of God's message in words like these:

> Your New Moon feasts and your appointed festivals I hate with all my being. They have become a burden to me; I am weary of bearing them. When you spread out your hands in prayer, I hide my eyes from you; even when you offer many prayers, I am not listening. Your hands are full of blood. (1:14-15)

> The eyes of the arrogant will be humbled and human pride brought low; the Lord alone will be exalted in that day. The Lord Almighty has a day in store for all the proud and lofty, for all that is exalted (and they will be humbled)." (2:11-12)
>
> The look on their faces testifies against them; they parade their sin like Sodom, they do not hide it. Woe to them! They have brought disaster upon themselves. (3:9)
>
> Woe to you who add house to house and join field to field till no space is left and you live alone in the land. The Lord Almighty has declared in my hearing; "Surely the great houses will become desolate, the fine mansions left without occupants." (5:8-9)
>
> Therefore Death expands its jaws, opening wide its mouth; into it will descend their nobles and masses with all their brawlers and revelers. So people will be brought low and everyone humbled, the eyes of the arrogant humbled. But the Lord Almighty will be exalted by his justice, and the holy God will be proved holy by his righteous acts. (5:14-16)
>
> Woe to those who call evil good and good evil, who put darkness for light and light for darkness, who put bitter for sweet and sweet for bitter.... Therefore, as tongues of fire lick up straw and as dry grass sinks down in the flames, so their roots will decay and their flowers blow away like dust; for they have rejected the law of the Lord Almighty and spurned the word of the Holy One of Israel. (5:20,24)

We've become a nation that brings out all manner of God-language when things go bad, but have no intention of doing what he says is right, or of avoiding what he says is wrong. We pick and choose from

the Bible what we like, and ignore the rest—and somehow God is supposed to be okay with that. So, when Jesus says, "Therefore what God has joined together, let no one separate" (Matthew 19:6), we decide to make it easy to end a marriage. The Bible (along with science) is clear that life begins at conception, but we decide that the consequences of sex can be inconvenient, so we hide behind a woman's "choice" and justify the murder of helpless victims. We don't even need the Bible to tell us that there are differences between men and women, and that sex is supposed to be between a man and a woman, yet we choose to ignore the obvious so we can allow anyone and everyone to be and do whatever they feel like doing, whatever their heart tells them is right for them. I often wonder how long we would be employed if we treated our employers like we treat God.

I stated earlier that I believe we're already experiencing God's wrath on our culture. In Romans 1:18-32, Paul describes what the wrath of God looks like on a people who have decided to flip off God. Notice first of all (in 1:18-20) that they knowingly turn their back on God; then they make their own gods with their own rules (1:21-23). America's god is not some idol made out of wood or stone, our god is self. We worship the individual, and individual rights. God's response to this is given in 1:24-32.

Note especially (in 1:18) that God's wrath is "being revealed"—present tense—through this. So I would argue that we're currently experiencing the wrath of God on our country. Three times in Romans 1 (in verses 24, 26, and 28) we read that God "gave them over" to something. This means that God allowed the full consequences of people's sin to play out in their society. There's a downward spiral into greater and greater wickedness and evil, until the tragic description in verses 29-32 becomes true of the culture. To me this seems to be a fairly accurate picture of our country. That's not to say there's nothing good happening, or that people do nothing but evil. But the overall situation is one

where we will do whatever we want, and we don't care what God thinks about it.

There's a passage in Deuteronomy that also makes me wonder if God has removed his blessing from America. Deuteronomy 28 describes the blessings that God will pour out on Israel if they "carefully follow all his commands" (28:1); it lists also the curses he will pour out on them if they "do not obey the Lord your God and do not carefully follow all his commands and decrees" (28:15). One of the blessings is this: "You will lend to many nations but will borrow from none" (28:12). Later in the text comes this curse:

> The foreigners who reside among you will rise above you higher and higher, but you will sink lower and lower. They will lend to you, but you will not lend to them. (28:43-44)

I realize that our national debt is a rather complicated economic issue, but it seems to me that if God was still blessing us, we wouldn't owe any money to other countries; they would owe us.

I truly believe our country is very deserving of God's judgment, and that this judgment actually could happen maybe sooner rather than later. But I also believe there is real hope, and that's what I'd like to focus on in the remaining chapters of this book.

6

The One We've Offended Is Our Only Hope

I knew that you are a gracious and compassionate God,

slow to anger and abounding in love,

a God who relents from sending calamity.

Jonah 4:2

I actually believe there is hope because of four different events in the Bible that demonstrate God's willingness to *not* judge a group of people who clearly deserve judgment.

One of these events is found in the book of Amos. The prophet Amos doesn't offer a lot of hope, because Israel in his day was too far gone. But there's a slight glimmer in chapter 5. Right after God recounts how he has done multiple things to get Israel's attention (he has been pleading with them to listen to him, yet they refused), he tells them, "Prepare to meet your God" (Amos 4:12). Then we read: "This is what the Lord says to Israel: 'Seek me and live; ... Seek the Lord and live, or he will sweep through the tribes of Joseph like a fire'" (5:4-6). Even as judgment is imminent, God gives them a last chance to seek him so he won't have to destroy them.

Another hopeful event is the story of Jonah. God gives Jonah the job of telling the residents of Nineveh, "Forty more days and Nineveh will be overthrown" (Jonah 3:4). The reason behind this doom for Nineveh was given earlier: "Its wickedness has come up before me" (1:2). Note here that God is well aware of the moral state of this nation and all nations. God was going to destroy Nineveh because they were so evil.

Most of us recall from this story how Jonah didn't want to go and give Nineveh this message—because he knew God was "gracious and compassionate...slow to anger and abounding in love, a God who relents from sending calamity" (4:2). Jonah hated these wicked Ninevites, and he feared that when they learned how much trouble they were in with God, this just might cause them to repent. Sure enough, this is exactly what happened.

Jonah therefore became so angry with God's mercy and compassion toward Nineveh that he wanted to die (4:3). It would seem that not all believers are happy when sinners repent. But the message is clear: When a group of people realize they've ticked off God to the point that he must destroy them, and they then repent—God is ready to relent, "and not bring on them the destruction he had threatened" (3:10).

Both of the other hopeful incidents I'll mention involve Moses and the people of Israel and God. First is the famous golden calf debacle (Exodus 32). God called Moses up on the mountain to give him the Ten Commandments. Meanwhile, the Israelites down below became impatient that Moses was gone for so long, and they demanded that Aaron make "gods who will go before us" (32:1). Aaron wimped out and gave in to their demands. He made a golden calf. Then the people proclaimed, "These are your gods, Israel, who brought you up out of Egypt" (32:4). Aaron even built an altar before this golden calf and proclaimed that the people would worship the Lord there.

God was extremely upset with this blasphemous display of idolatry. He basically tells Moses to get out of the way because he's going to completely wipe out every last person in Israel and start all over again with Moses (32:7-10). Note that in verse 7, God basically disowns Israel when he says to Moses, "Go down, because *your* people, whom *you* brought up out of Egypt have become corrupt." All of a sudden these are Moses' kids. Then Moses prays (32:11-13), after which "the Lord re-

lented and did not bring on his people the disaster he had threatened" (32:14). This people deserved to be wiped out, but an amazing prayer changed God's mind, and he was merciful.

Later, in Numbers 13 and 14, we find a similar prayer from Moses which once again stops God from wiping out all of Israel and starting over with Moses. This time it was because the people decided to believe the negative report of the spies who were sent out to explore the Promised Land. Caleb and Joshua and even Moses and Aaron begged the people to trust God and not rebel against him. But the people were so entrenched in their rebellion that they even considered killing Moses, Aaron, Caleb, and Joshua (14:10). Once again, God was beyond upset. He states that he intends to "strike them down with a plague and destroy them"; then Moses prays again, and God relents and forgives (14:13-20).

All four of these events have in common a group of people who have greatly offended the God of the universe, and he justly and deservedly decides to destroy them. In the situation with Amos, I believe that if the people of the Northern Kingdom had listened to this prophet, God would have relented there too. But they refused, and instead they attacked and made fun of God's prophet. They paid the ultimate price. Two of the other events show that effective praying has a huge impact on God. Jonah shows us that even when the prophet's heart is not in his message, people can be persuaded to repent, and then God does not judge.

Where can we find someone today who will pray like Moses prayed? Where can we find someone who will proclaim God's truth like Jonah did? My hope is that the church in America will be Moses and Jonah to our country, and I pray that through the church our nation will turn to God.

In Ezekiel 22:30, God says, "I looked for someone among them who would build up the wall and stand before me in the gap on behalf of the land so I would not have to destroy it, but I found no one." This is a sad verse, yet at the same time a hopeful verse. This chapter of Ezekiel's prophecy sums up all the problems God has with the Jewish people and how he is going to judge her. The wall has been torn down, and there's no protection from the enemy—God himself, in this instance. The "wall" that protects them is listening to God and doing things his way. They've ignored the clear teachings and warnings of Scripture and are arrogantly doing everything God says is wrong. The last thing he tells them here is that if one man would have started to build up the wall and then stood in the gap to protect the land from God's judgment, God would not destroy it. Notice his wording: "I would not *have* to destroy it."

God's character means that he cannot ignore the sins of the nation—he must destroy it. That's the scary part. The hopeful part is that he doesn't *want* to destroy it. He's looking for someone to actually do something to keep him from having to destroy the land.

I hope that the church in America will be that man. Is the church up to the task?

7

What Condition Our Condition Is In

Jerusalem lies in ruins,

and its gates have been burned with fire.

Come, let us rebuild the wall of Jerusalem,

and we will no longer be in disgrace.

Nehemiah 2:17

The last seventy years (my lifetime) have seen a dramatic and ever increasing moral decline in America. Where has the church been?

In his book *Thriving in Babylon,* Larry Osborne states, "If you haven't noticed, the culture wars are over. We lost."[8] Sadly, I agree with him. We are supposed to be salt and light in this world (Matthew 5:13-16). Jesus said this about his church: "The gates of Hades will not overcome it" (Matthew 16:18). What has happened to or in the church that we no longer have any significant influence over our culture?

I think we've been lulled into a false sense of security. After all, we're believers and we live in the greatest nation in the world—so what could go wrong? We're like an athletic team about to play the big game, but we're taking the other team for granted: *All we have to do is show up, and we win*. I also think some of us are maybe a little shell-shocked at how quickly and drastically our country's morality has deteriorated. In either case, the result is the same: too many of us are sitting in the stands instead of taking the field and engaging the enemy.

Some of us are thinking, "I have my eternity all figured out, so I can just coast." We're presuming upon grace. Others of us are uncertain what to do about the state of our country, and we think there's nothing we can do—so we, too, are coasting, waiting to see what will happen.

I wonder if one of the reasons many of us might be sitting in the stands and just watching is actually theological. A great many evangelicals have been greatly influenced by premillennial dispensational eschatology. Hal Lindsey's *The Late Great Planet Earth*, published in 1970, popularized this understanding of Christ's return, along with the 1972 film *A Thief in the Night,* plus the *Left Behind* fiction series (published between 1995 and 2007) by Tim LaHaye and Jerry B. Jenkins. Lindsey's book sold over 35 million copies, and 80 million were sold of the *Left Behind* series; many additional books and movies with a similar end-times viewpoint have been produced in the last forty years. A major aspect of this popularized viewpoint is that the world is going to get really bad before Christ will return—which leads many to conclude that there's therefore nothing we can or should do about our country's slide into wickedness and evil. That's a response I've often heard from people I've talked to about this. It almost seems like they *want* things to become worse, so Christ will return sooner.

Certainly the desire for Christ's soon return is biblical and commendable, but to use this theology as a reason to sit back and do nothing is certainly not biblical. Think with me about Judah's exile to Babylon for seventy years because of their national sin. And yet, through the prophet Jeremiah, God told them to "seek the peace and prosperity of the city to which I have carried you into exile. Pray to the Lord for it, because if it prospers, you too will prosper" (Jeremiah 29:7). Why should we not be doing the same thing for America—seeking this nation's peace and prosperity, and praying for it?

Plus, when I read the words of Jesus in Matthew 24 and 25, he seems to be clearly teaching that no one knows when he'll return, or how long we must wait for it; therefore God expects us to be doing what he has told us to do. We're to make sure our light is still shining when he returns, as we persevere in doing whatever makes God look good (Matthew 25:1-13; see also 5:14-16). When Jesus returns, will he find

us taking care of our brothers and sisters in Christ (24:45-51) by putting their interests ahead of our own? Will he find us consciously using our natural abilities and talents plus our spiritual gifts (25:14-30) to benefit His kingdom?

I just don't see where God allows us to sit in the stands and watch, for whatever reason. Look at what God did when Jonah, with a really bad attitude, preached to Nineveh. Or what if Moses had simply stood aside when God was so upset by the golden calf, or by the negativity of the ten spies and the resultant rebellion by Israel? Moses legitimately could have been thinking that these people were rebellious complainers who deserved judgment, but Moses prayed, and God was merciful.

Yes, our country is in real trouble, and a time is coming when things will be so bad that God will intervene. But our God is merciful, and just maybe if the church will get out of the stands and get on the field, his undeserved mercy will be shown to our country.

All this is not to say that the church is doing nothing at all. Many believers are engaged in great ministries that are having an impact on their communities and our culture, but it's hard to ignore the truth that our country has been steadily—at an accelerating pace—turning their backs on God. The church needs to get on the field and get in the game.

That's what Nehemiah did. This man heard that God's people who had returned to the Promised Land after the seventy years of exile were "in great trouble and disgrace" (Nehemiah 1:3). Is God's church a disgrace in America? Are we that bad?

In Constantine R. Campbell's book *Jesus v. Evangelicals: A Biblical Critique of a Wayward Movement,* the author states,

> By fighting for political influence no matter the cost, evangelicals are no longer viewed as trustworthy arbiters of spiritual

> truth. They are seen not as Jesus' representatives in the world but as power-hungry, self-interested hypocrites.[9]

Ouch! Later, Campbell says,

> Rightly or wrongly, evangelicals must reckon with the reality that they are perceived as intolerant, judgmental, and exclusivist.[10]

Double ouch! Is this the public perception of the church—the church that has been commanded to love God with every part of our being, and to love others (including our neighbors) as we love ourselves?

Nehemiah was so upset by this report of trouble and disgrace in Jerusalem and Judah that for several days he "mourned and fasted" (Nehemiah 1:4). He received permission from the king to return to Jerusalem so he could rebuild the city and its wall. Nehemiah's first action when he arrived there was to ride around the city and evaluate the situation before he took action. I think a ride around the walls of the church is in order for us today, so we can determine what needs to be fixed in order to be Jonah and Moses to America. (I also think prayer and fasting are excellent ideas—which we'll discuss in a later chapter.)

I believe that the church in America has two very powerful things going for it that we can hopefully use to rebuild the wall and stand in the gap before God, so he doesn't have to destroy our country. The first truth is that the church belongs to Jesus, and he promises that "the gates of Hades will not overcome it" (Matthew 16:18). We may be down, but we are not out.

The second thing going for us is that we're very much like the New Testament church—we're far from perfect, yet since God used them to change the world, why not us?

I've read many books over the years that critically evaluate the American church, and each of these has challenged me to evaluate myself and the church I pastored. The author who has helped me most wasn't actually writing directly about the church in America, yet his writings have always rung true, and I think his insights are extremely helpful. His name is Saul of Tarsus, but he wrote under the pseudonym of Paul.

The church in Saul's day—before his conversion—had been guilty of things like discrimination (Acts 6:1), direct disobedience to the last command Jesus gave them before he ascended into heaven—when he told them to be his "witnesses in...Samaria and to the ends of the earth" (1:8). They were perfectly content to stay in Jerusalem where God was blessing and doing amazing things (2:41; 4:4). There's no indication that they were even thinking about reaching Samaria and the ends of the earth until God raised up a persecution to get them working outside of Jerusalem and Judea. God had to give Peter—the key leader of the church—three visions just to make him tell a Gentile about Jesus (Acts 10). A whole bunch of Gentiles became believers—but instead of rejoicing, many in the church called Peter on the carpet for the sin of eating with Gentiles in their home. Thankfully, when Peter related to everyone how God had worked and had given the Holy Spirit to these Gentiles, all was well. The New Testament church at last recognized what God was up to: "So then, even to Gentiles God has granted repentance that leads to life" (Acts 11:1-18).

Now that Saul was saved and was planting churches, things would surely be different—the churches planted by Paul the apostle would certainly do everything right. Well, not exactly. Paul wrote to a group of churches that were in danger of "turning to a different gospel" (Galatians 1:7). This was so dangerous that Paul forgot to begin his letter to them with thanksgiving for what God was doing in their lives. But he must have learned his lesson, because when he wrote to the church that was divided over which pastor was the greatest, and over who was

the most spiritual because of their special gifts, and over how to deal with a man who was committing sexual immorality "of a kind that even pagans do not tolerate" (among other less than Christlike behaviors), Paul was careful to begin his letter to them by saying, "I always thank my God for you" (1 Corinthians 1:4). Paul also had to rebuke Peter because Peter forgot the lesson he'd learned via three visions from God about Gentiles (Galatians 2:11-14). Paul's writings reveal that the New Testament church, which we all want to be like, was full of broken forgiven sinners who on a fairly regular basis failed to do things the way they were supposed to. Yet God used that church to change the world.

Only God knows if the church in America is worse or better than the New Testament church, and only God can take a bunch of broken forgiven sinners and change the world. The church today is still the church of Jesus Christ that will not be overcome by the gates of Hades. God used a bunch of imperfect churches to change the Roman Empire in the past, and I pray that in America he'll again use the imperfect church to protect us from God's judgment.

8

Do You See What I See?

But who can discern their own errors?

Forgive my hidden faults.

Psalm 19:12

Yes, God can use imperfect churches, but we need to repent of our sin. I believe the major sin of the church in America is a self-centeredness that has undermined the two most powerful arguments in the eyes of the world for the truth of Christianity: our unity and our love.

Again, I'm not a prophet, so this is just my take on what has caused the church to lose the culture wars. I believe we've become a people who care more about ourselves than we do about the kingdom of God. I believe that the values of our culture have infected the church without our realizing it.

I doubt many people would disagree that our nation has become extremely self-centered over the last few decades. We've become a nation that demands our rights. We've turned the ideals of individualism and the basic rights of every human being into a quest for whatever makes me happy. We've turned "government of the people, by the people, for the people" into government of the people, by the people—*for me*. Moral relativism is the dominant world view of most Americans, so each of us determines what's right for us, and woe to anyone who dares to tell us we're wrong. Hallmark and Hollywood have taught us to let our own heart be our ultimate guide, so we're a culture that makes our feelings the final arbiter for right or wrong. Companies spend billions of dollars on advertising that promotes the idea that each of us will be

happier and better off if we'll just use their product. Almost without exception, they're appealing to our what's-best-for-*me* attitude.

The overall result of all this is that America has become a supremely self-centered, me-first society.

Surely Christians don't think like that, right? Sadly, I believe we think a lot more like it than we realize. Most Bible-believing Christians in America are doing very well, and I think we've become too complacent and satisfied with life. Paul David Tripp in his 2014 devotional book *New Morning Mercies: A Daily Gospel Devotional* calls it "spiritual self-satisfaction." This book's devotional for October 25 is spot-on for the American church, so I'll quote it here at length:

> We all tend to share in a big, bad personal problem. It's one that doesn't get much press or pulpit time. Yet this problem is a huge interrupter of our personal spiritual development. If you have this problem, you won't be concerned that you have this problem precisely because you have this problem! I confess that I think this is a big deal for me as well. The problem is *personal spiritual self-satisfaction.* The more I travel from church to church, the more I engage with leaders and the more I have opportunities to interview people in the seats, the more I grow convinced that the true crisis in the modern evangelical church is not dissatisfaction; it's the opposite. We're too satisfied. We're all too satisfied with who we are, where we are, and what we're doing. We're satisfied with a little bit of biblical literacy. We're satisfied with occasional moments of ministry. We're satisfied with manageable debt that allows us to put a few coins in the plate. We're satisfied that we've been married for a while and it doesn't look as if we'll break up soon. We're satisfied with a bit of a grasp on the theology of Scripture. We're satisfied with faithful at-

> tendance at the weekend services of our churches. We're satisfied with quick morning devotions. We're satisfied with a little ministry experience. We're satisfied that we don't act out most of our lust and we don't communicate most of our envy. We're satisfied that in our disappointment with God, we don't walk away. We're satisfied that we can harness a good bit of our fear of man. We're satisfied to use most of our material resources to make and keep ourselves comfortable. We're satisfied to be mere consumers of the work of the church rather than committed participants in it. We're satisfied with hearts that occasionally wander and with thoughts that contradict what the Bible says is good and true. We're satisfied with the amount of conflict we have in our lives. We're satisfied.

Hear again these words: "If you have this problem, you won't be concerned that you have this problem precisely because you have this problem!" This is exactly the danger the church in America faces. We don't even realize that we've become too self-centered and satisfied with life.

If my analysis of our culture is anywhere close to correct, and America really is in danger of being judged by God, and the church is our only hope—then the church needs to get out of the stands where we're watching the game, and get onto the field and join the battle.

Is it really as bad as I seem to think it is? There are a number of reasons to think we've become more like our culture than we would like to admit.

9

Who, Me?

Encourage one another daily,

as long as it is called "Today,"

so that none of you may be hardened

by sin's deceitfulness.

Hebrews 3:13

One of the more humbling truths for we Christians to face is that we aren't objective about our own sin. In Psalm 19:12, David says, "Who can discern their own errors? Forgive my hidden faults." David is acknowledging here that no one can see their own sin. Sure, we know we sin, and a lot of our sin is obvious, but there are also many sins that we're totally unaware of. And unless and until God shows us, we can do very little about them.

Hebrews 13:3 tells us that we need to "encourage one another everyday" so that none of us "may be hardened by sin's deceitfulness." Sin deceives us, so we need one another to help us see the stuff about ourselves that we really don't want to see. How many of us have intentionally given another believer permission to be honest with us about things they see in us that might not reflect Christ the way we want? Could this be one of the primary benefits of marriage? Maybe this is why Jesus told us when we pray that we should ask God to "deliver us from evil and lead us not into temptation." Could our lack of objectivity be blinding us to our self-satisfied self-centeredness?

One example of this is what I call the Styrofoam Cup Syndrome. At the church I pastored, there was always coffee available during the week at our offices. A lot of people would stop in just to get a free cup of cof-

fee and often stay and visit for a few minutes. We provided two sizes of Styrofoam cups that were stacked next to the coffee machine for those who came by. Those cups came in plastic sleeves that were stored in the cupboards near the coffee machine. When one size of cup was gone, the next person who wanted that size cup would have to get out a new sleeve of cups, open it, and take a cup. I thought it would have been obvious that the rest of the cups should be taken out of the sleeve at the same time and placed on the counter by the coffee pot, because other people would also need a cup. However, that was rarely the case. Most often, people would just take out one cup for themselves and put the opened sleeve of cups back in the cupboard (though I admit some people may have mistakenly thought that was where all the cups were meant to be kept). Of course the reason they had to open a sleeve in the first place was because the person who took the last cup did not get more cups out for others. I cannot tell you how many times I would go to put more cups on the counter (I probably drank the most coffee), and I would find an open sleeve with one cup gone. Didn't they know that someone else would need a cup too?

This is certainly not a major deal, but it illustrates well what I believe is one of the major weaknesses of the church today. We're not intentionally thinking about the needs of others. We take care of our own need without thinking beyond that. Our churches include good people who are trying to serve God; they're hard workers and solid citizens. But we often fail to see the simple needs of others. We fail to think beyond our own needs. It is humbling to realize that if the roles were reversed and I was the one needing a cup, I would very likely also have just taken one cup and put the rest of the sleeve back in the cupboard.

It would be easy to say that this situation with coffee cups in our church office was such a small thing, maybe even petty, so why make so much of it? It is small, but does it reveal a bigger issue? Does it reveal that in

general we take care of our own wants and needs without considering how others would be impacted?

10

God's View of Greatness

And the second is like it:

"Love your neighbor as yourself."

Matthew 22:39

The passage known as the Great Commandment is another teaching of Jesus that's familiar to most of us, yet I'm not sure we get the true implications of it. Let's take a closer look.

When Jesus was asked to identify the greatest commandment, he said, "Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind. And the second is like it: Love your neighbor as yourself" (Matthew 22:36-39). It's that second part—loving your neighbor as yourself—that I think we don't pay enough attention to. It seems to me that Jesus is telling us we don't love others as much as we love ourselves.

I remember early in my ministry when the truth of this text hit me right between the eyes. I realized that the implication of what Jesus was saying is that I struggle to love others as much as I love myself. If we could just get to the place where we loved others as much as we do ourselves, this would be an amazing world to live in. I was very humbled by this realization. It made me realize I was a lot more about "me" than I was about others.

Jesus didn't teach this just to me, but to us all, so I think we can conclude that all people—Christians included—struggle to love others as much as they love themselves.

We all struggle with the flesh, so if we're honest, we know it's hard to actually love others to this degree. Think about the twelve disciples. None

of us would say we're better than they were, so let's look at one of the biggest struggles in their lives: the issue of which one of those twelve was the greatest. Remember that these guys lived in a culture with few if any personal rights whatsoever. And they weren't bombarded by advertising telling them that life is all about one's own happiness and well-being. Yet on three separate occasions, we see them having to be taught by Jesus that true greatness comes by being humble and a servant to others. Why would Jesus have to actually verbalize this idea? Certainly, his own example was enough, you would think. Seeing the life he lived would be a picture worth well over a thousand words, right? Apparently not.

Luke 9:46-48 records one of those moments when the disciples were arguing among themselves about which of them was the greatest. Jesus explains to them that it's the *least* among them who is the greatest.

Later, the disciples James and John send their mom to ask Jesus for positions of prominence for them both, once Jesus came into his kingdom (Matthew 10:35-45; Mark 10:35-45). This made the rest of the disciples upset with James and John. Personally, I believe they were upset not because of what James and John had requested, but because they hadn't thought of asking for it first.

Jesus rebukes all twelve of them by saying that true greatness is in being a servant. He then gives that famous example: "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45).

Of course, after this, these guys understood quite well what true greatness was, and it would never be an issue again—except that it was, at the Last Supper. This incident at the Last Supper was one of the lowest points in the disciples' time with Jesus, perhaps exceeded only by their fleeing for their lives when Jesus was arrested.

Jesus had started that evening by washing the disciples' feet and telling them,

> You call me "Teacher" and "Lord," and rightly so, for that is what I am. Now that I, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also should wash one another's feet. I have set you an example that you should do as I have done for you. Very truly I tell you, no servant is greater than his master, nor is a messenger greater than the one who sent him. Now that you know these things, you will be blessed if you do them. (John 13:13-17)

This was a living example of the servanthood Jesus expected from his followers. It could not be any plainer. Yet in the middle of this meal—right after Jesus has held the first communion service—we read this: "A dispute arose among them as to which of them was considered to be greatest" (Luke 22:24). Jesus' patience in this situation is amazing. Most of us would not be kind to these men under these circumstances. Once more, Jesus has to teach them the same thing he'd gone over with them before—and which he'd demonstrated so profoundly that very evening—about how true greatness was being a servant. For three years they'd walked with Jesus, and still they failed to understand servanthood.

Again, we're no better than those guys. Moreover, unlike them, we live in a culture that glorifies self, so how selfish are we really? Are we, the church, even willing to ask that question? Are we willing to ask God how well we're doing at loving our neighbor as ourselves?

Another element that has really hurt us in loving our neighbor as ourselves is some very poor Christian teaching on this verse. I remember a time early in my ministry when some Christian psychologists were telling people that what Jesus meant by saying "Love your neighbor

as yourself" was that we can't truly love others until we learn to love ourselves—we must develop a positive self-image before we can actually love someone else. I can remember Christians telling me that they had to "work on themselves" before they could help anyone else. Just like in the garden of Eden, Satan has once again twisted Scripture and conned us. A positive self-image does not come from loving yourself first. It comes from understanding that we were once totally estranged from the holy God of the universe, and that even our best good deeds "are like filthy rags" (Isaiah 64:6) in God's sight—but the holy God has loved us so much that he sent his only Son into the world to be punished for our sins, so we could be forgiven. And that same holy God—by his grace, through his Holy Spirit—has enabled us to believe in what Jesus did for us on the cross, so that by putting our faith in Jesus we're now made right in God's eyes, and God considers us to be "his glorious inheritance" (Ephesians 1:18). The biblical way to "feel good about ourselves" is to focus on who God says we are in Christ, and on what God says we have in Christ, and then serving others (Mark 10:41-45). Jesus says that serving others is true greatness. And when God and Jesus call us great, how can it get any better than that?

Add to all of this the fact that so many of the worship choruses we sing in our churches are largely first-person singular ("I" and "me") instead of plural ("we" or "us"). Even some of the songs we sing in worship of our God tend to tell us that it's all about us. We've truly become a people who are spiritually self-satisfied. I liken it to sitting in the stands and watching the game instead of being on the field and playing the game. The only spectators in the Bible are the saints who have gone before us (Hebrews 12:1), and they paid (with their own lives of suffering and sacrifice) to see us competing, not sitting and watching.

I can imagine you may be thinking, "Wait a minute—sure, we all struggle with selfishness sometimes, but I know selfishness is wrong, and I'm not a selfish person." Often when we know something's wrong, we fail

to see it in ourselves because we know it *shouldn't* be there—therefore it *isn't* there. Maybe if we look at what Jesus expects of us, we'll have a clearer picture of what we've become without even realizing it.

11

How's Our Love Life?

A new command I give you: Love one another.

As I have loved you, so you must love one another.

By this everyone will know that you are my disciples,

if you love one another.

John 13:34-35

In John 13, Jesus gave his disciples this "new command." But how is this command "new"? What does this love look like? How has Jesus loved us?

Think with me about Jesus' ministry, and we'll see some amazing examples of what it means to love others. How about the time he and his disciples were so tired that they needed to get away, but when they arrived at the place where they were supposed to rest and recuperate, the crowds were there ahead of them. What does Jesus do? He has compassion on the crowds, so he teaches them, and then makes sure they have enough to eat (Mark 6:30-44).

Or what about the time he would actually reach out and touch a leper, a person no one else would have physical contact with (Matthew 8:2).

And of course, there's that famous example of meeting other's needs when he washed the disciples' feet before the Last Supper.

But I think one of the most overlooked examples of his putting others' needs ahead of his own was in the further teaching he gave the disciples on that night of the Last Supper. He knew that they would soon be falling asleep in Gethsemane while he himself was agonizing in prayer over what was about to happen to him. He knew they would abandon

him at his hour of greatest need, and that Peter would even deny knowing him. So did Jesus berate them? *No!* He understood how awful they would be feeling about themselves in a very short while, so he spoke these words to them:

> Do not let your hearts be troubled. You believe in God; believe also in me. My Father's house has many rooms; if that were not so, would I have told you that I am going there to prepare a place for you? And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come back and take you to be with me that you also may be where I am. (John 14:1-3)

Read chapters 14–16 in John's Gospel, and notice that everything Jesus tells them is for their benefit. Jesus is thinking fully about them and their needs at a time when he's about to go through the most difficult experience of his life. It's not until later, when he goes to Gethsemane to pray, that he focuses on his upcoming suffering and what it would mean for him. I cannot imagine this kind of love.

One last example stands out: In the midst of the agony of dying on a cross, Jesus made sure his mother would be taken care of when he was no longer on earth (John 19:25-27). Again, in the midst of unimaginable physical and emotional pain and suffering, Jesus was thinking of the needs of others.

Jesus tells us to love one another "as I have loved you" (John 13:34). Are we—the church in America—loving each other like this?

Philippians 2:6-11 also helps us understand the newness of Christ's "new command." It's the famous passage which speaks to how Jesus "emptied" himself so that he could serve us. We read here that he willingly gave up all the glory of heaven—all the worship he was used to receiving, all the rights and privileges attached to his being equal to God the Father. He did not hold on to his position or his rights, but

laid them down, putting them completely aside, so he could come into this world for our salvation, in obedience to his Father. I don't think we can even imagine what it must have been like for God's Son to leave heaven and not just visit this world, but live in it for thirty-plus years. I think of that scene in the film *The Shawshank Redemption* where Andy (the main character) escapes from prison by crawling five hundred yards through a sewer pipe with fresh sewage running through it. I don't think that even a sewer can begin to describe the difference between the glory of heaven and this sin-wracked world we live in.

To further describe Christ's humiliation, the text in Philippians 2 goes on to say that he took on human form and the nature of a servant. He then completed his humiliation by dying the most shameful and gruesome death anyone could imagine. We know that he did all this for the human race—for us!—to rescue us from our sin's consequence, which is eternal separation from God in hell. In Romans 3:25, Paul tells us that Jesus, in his death, was taking upon himself all the wrath of God against our sin. The real point of all of this, according to Paul, is that Jesus is our example of what we must be willing to do in order to be looking not only to our own interests, "but also to the interests of the others." (Philippians 2:4)

I think that too often when we look at this passage, we miss the main point. It's not so much about what Jesus gave up so he could serve us, but about the fact that we believers are supposed to follow his example by giving up our rights and humbling ourselves so we can serve others. We're called to "have the same mindset as Christ Jesus" (2:5). Jesus emptied himself on our behalf, and this is the example we're to emulate in our relationships with our brothers and sisters in Christ.

Just prior to this famous passage in Philippians 2, Paul had written of his desire for the Philippian believers to "stand firm in the one Spirit, striving together as one for the faith of the gospel" (Philippians 1:27).

When we think of our own local church, is this what stands out to us? Is our church working hard together to promote the gospel, so we can all be encouraged by the amazing truths of what we have in Christ, and so that unbelievers will put their faith in Jesus because they see us setting aside our own agendas to accomplish a higher purpose?

Would Paul have joy if he could see our churches today? In Philippians 2:2, he speaks of how his own "joy" is made "complete" when these believers are "like-minded, having the same love, being one in spirit and of one mind." Is that us? It doesn't mean that we all must always have the exact same thoughts; it means rather that there's something out there more important than our personal preferences and rights, and we must be willing to give those up so that together we can fulfill our calling as the church. Paul says we're to let go of all "selfish ambition and vain conceit," and to humbly "consider others better" than ourselves (2:3). We make an intentional mental decision that the rights and preferences of our fellow believers in our local church are more important than our own rights and preferences.

How many of us have prayerfully made the decision that everyone else in our local church is more important than we are—and then attempted to live it out? What would that look like?

Think about a team sport like football. The goal of every football team is to win each game by scoring more points than their opponent. Each team has its own personality and strengths and weaknesses, its own way of playing the game; some teams focus on their passing game, some on their running game, still others on their defense. But the higher purpose—to win each game—is always the same. Toward that end, each player on the team has a uniquely specific role on every play. Some players may appear to be more important than others because they get to handle the ball, but without the linemen who block for them, they would look really bad. The coach decides which play to run and in-

forms the quarterback, who then informs the rest of the team; then they all work together to run that particular play, which brings a result; sometimes great things happen (like a touchdown), while sometimes things don't work out so well. But together they keep on running plays to accomplish their shared goal.

The main idea here is that each player fulfills their particular role for the benefit of the team, not for themselves. A lineman can't say, "That's a stupid play to call, so this time I refuse to block." When the running back knows he won't be handed the ball on a particular play, he doesn't just stand around and watch. And the receiver cannot run whatever route he feels like running; he must follow the route each play calls for, or else the quarterback will look for him in a certain location so he can pass the ball to him, but the receiver won't be there, and the play will fail. Each player must give up their own personal preferences and rights for the benefit of the entire team. There's no way any team can win the game unless every player is willing to do this on every play. And no church can accomplish what God has called them to do unless each member is willing to live out what we're instructed to do together in Philippians 2.

Some really astounding things happen when we decide to do church the way Paul tells us to in that passage. We've already seen that Jesus tells us (in John 13:34-35) how this kind of loving unity shows the world that we are his disciples. Jesus also tells us—through his prayer in John 17:20-23—that this is how the world (unbelievers) will know that Jesus came from God, and that God loves them. When we love each other as God has loved us, we're showing God to those around us (1 John 4:10-12). What an amazing and powerful thing it is to give up our preferences and rights for the benefit of our fellow believers.

So how is this kind of love a "new" commandment? Remember that when Jesus identified the greatest commandment as loving God with

all of our being, he immediately said that we're also to "love our neighbors as ourselves." I think Jesus has now upped the ante. He's saying that we are now expected to love one another *more* than we love ourselves. Remember how he told his disciples to love each other "even as I have loved you" (John 13:34). Jesus' love for us is clearly more than his love for himself—and God expects us to follow that example. Paul tells us to "value others above yourselves" (Philippians 2:3). How are we doing at that? Is this what stands out to people when they think about our local churches? I think it's hard to deny that the American church has in large measure not practiced this kind of love. Maybe we're a lot more self-centered and self-satisfied than we like to think.

Is it actually possible to love like this—to the same degree that Jesus loved? Isn't that just a little too unrealistic? Granted, this is a very high bar, but we have the Holy Spirit indwelling us. The Old Testament people did not. We know that we're forgiven and that God has our back and that he will never forsake us or give up on us (Romans 8:28-39). Not only that, but God promises to exalt us when we decide to not exalt ourselves. As Paul says in Philippians 2:9-11, because Jesus was willing to empty himself, "God exalted him to the highest place." We won't be exalted exactly like Jesus was (and is), because he is King of kings and Lord of lords, but the text clearly teaches that God honors greatly those who give up their rights to serve others. Peter also speaks of this: "Humble yourselves, therefore, under God's mighty hand, that he may lift you up in due time" (1 Peter 5:6). We humble ourselves under the protection of God's power, and God exalts us in his time and his way.

What Peter says next— "Cast all your anxiety on him because he cares for you" (5:7)—has always been an encouragement to me. God seems to be acknowledging that humbling ourselves for the benefit of others will likely create anxiety in our lives. So Peter is telling us we can and should be honest with God about how hard it is to put others ahead of ourselves, because God really does care about us. Yes, though it is cer-

tainly difficult, God thinks we can do it with his help—and the New Testament seems to be clear that he also expects it of us.

Jesus never envisioned a church that wasn't actively involved in pursuing God, loving each other more than themselves, and pursuing other people so they too could know the God who loves them so much that he gave his Son so they could live in heaven with God instead of spending eternity in hell with the devil. The church Paul was writing to lived in the midst of a completely pagan society with a tyrannical ruler, with no modern technology, and where the rights we have as Americans were almost totally absent. Yet God used that imperfect, broken, forgiven group of believers to change the world. They had no political aspirations or power; they were just being and doing what Jesus told the church to be and do.

Those churches were far from perfect, so it strikes me that the church in America—which is also made up of imperfect, broken, forgiven people—can also change our world. Jesus gave us our marching orders in the Great Commission passages of the Gospels and Acts 1:8. The One with all authority in heaven and on earth goes with us. We have the indwelling Holy Spirit empowering us.

I believe that the church in America can build up the wall and stand before God in the gap so he doesn't have to destroy our land—if we're willing to confess our self-centered, self-satisfied living, to humble ourselves before God, and to turn and make his kingdom more important to us than anything else, including ourselves.

12

Repentance Is Necessary

Those whom I love I rebuke and discipline.

So be earnest and repent.

Revelation 3:19

Chapters 2 and 3 in the book of Revelation record Jesus' words to seven of the earliest churches. Five of these seven are told clearly of their need to repent (only the churches at Smyrna and Philadelphia are spared this command). Each of those five churches has a different set of issues that Jesus points out, and in each case the solution is repentance. It's important to notice that Jesus loves these churches. That is why he's pointing out their shortcomings and challenging them to repent.

I have been saying that America is in grave danger from God, who is holy and just, and that our only hope is the church. I don't think anyone can disagree with me on the seriousness of what I've said are the three things our country is doing that really tick God off. We cannot expect the unsaved to repent of these sins—they think there's nothing wrong there, and until they come to know Jesus and submit to his understanding of right and wrong, they will not change. It's the job and mission of the church to give them the message of salvation through faith in Christ. Only then can this nation repent of these sins.

My argument has been this: Where was the church when all these sinful things became the law of the land? What was the church doing while our culture was making dramatic shifts in everyone's thinking about God and about what is right and wrong, and about who has the right to decide what's right and wrong? I believe that we, in our self-centeredness, have become a reflection of our culture instead of a re-

flection of Jesus and his self-sacrificing love for others. We, the church, need to do some Spirit-led examination—corporately and individually—and then repent and make the changes God will show us.

Psalm 19:12-14 and 139:23-24 are good places to start. I've already said that none of us are objective about our sin, and Psalm 19:12 confirms that we're unable to discern our own errors, and that we all have "hidden faults." Therefore, praying Psalm 139:23-24 would be a great place to start in asking God to show us if we are as self-centered as I have maintained we are.

I can remember thinking, "Why would I want God to show me all the stuff in my life that's offensive to him?" It seemed like it would be pretty discouraging. And it would be, unless we remember that in Christ we are totally and completely forgiven. On the cross, Jesus took care of all God's wrath against our sin, so that God never condemns us. What an amazing truth! Actually, when God reveals our "hidden faults" (and any other stuff he thinks we need to take care of), and the Spirit reminds us that "we are God's children" and "heirs of God and co-heirs with Christ" (Romans 8:16-17), this can become a time of rejoicing as we're reminded of how great God's forgiveness is.

I must emphasize once more that I'm not claiming that God has personally told me these things. I am not like the Old Testament prophets who had direct revelation from God to Israel. But if you believe there is any validity at all to my concern, I think we should check it out with God, because we certainly don't want to experience God's judgment on our country. Of course, no one writes a book like this without having some idea of what they think ought to be done. I want to share with you some suggestions on how we can change and quit being a self-satisfied, self-centered spectator, and get on the field where we belong, to engage the enemy and win the game.

13

But I Didn't Do That

We have sinned and done wrong.

We have been wicked and have rebelled;

we have turned away from your commands and laws.

Daniel 9:5

The first and maybe the most humbling thing we need to do is to acknowledge that *we* have sinned as a country, and as the church.

Look again at the prayer of confession at the head of this chapter. The person who prayed this prayer must have been a really bad sinner, right? Actually he was the exact opposite. This is Daniel, one of the four men God used to cause an arrogant king to humble himself and tell his whole kingdom (the Babylonian Empire) that God was the true God whom everyone should worship. Daniel was a godly man who entrusted himself to God again and again, and he saw God do amazing things in and through his life. Why would someone like Daniel pray like this and confess such wickedness and sin? It was because Daniel—and others like him, as we shall see—understood the corporate responsibility for sin.

The Bible is very clear on this truth, but the concept goes against the individualism of our culture, both nationally and in the church—which is why the church largely ignores it.

The story of Achan in Joshua 7 demonstrates that one man's sin had negative consequences for the whole community. The Israelites were told to stay away from "the devoted things"; they were warned that violating this prohibition would "bring about your own destruction.... You will make *the camp of Israel liable to destruction and bring trouble on it*"

(Joshua 6:18). God clearly warns them that the whole camp will suffer if anyone takes some of the devoted things.

A guy named Achan decided to ignore this command (7:1, 7:20-21). As a result, when Israel attacked the next city, they were defeated, and thirty-six Israeli soldiers were killed. (7:4-5). Joshua was devastated over this defeat. He fell down before the Lord and basically accused him of letting them down and setting up the whole nation for destruction (7:7-9).

God had no patience with Joshua on this one. He said Joshua had no business being on his face—he should get up and acknowledge the fact that "Israel has sinned; they have violated my covenant, which I commanded them to keep" (7:11). Notice that God does not say that a particular individual had sinned, but rather that *Israel* has sinned. One person's sin affected everyone else.

It's also true that the sins of a nation often have a negative impact on the godly people of that nation. One example of this is found in the book of Daniel. Daniel and his three friends are clearly living for God, yet they're taken captive along with many other Jews when Nebuchadnezzar first attacked Jerusalem in 605 B.C. God raised up the Babylonians specifically to punish Judah (the Southern kingdom) because of their rebellion against God. There were actually three deportations of Jews by Nebuchadnezzar; the second came in 597, when the prophet Ezekiel was among those taken captive; and the final one came in 587, when Nebuchadnezzar totally destroyed and burned Jerusalem. The sins of the nation negatively impacted some very godly men, the most famous being Daniel, his three friends, and Ezekiel. They were all taken captive—not because of their personal sins, but because of the sin of Judah.

We're all Americans; therefore, even though we're personally against no-fault divorce, abortion, and LGBTQ lifestyles, our country is for those things, and since we're part of our country, we have sinned. I

gather that many believers in America think that somehow our country cannot be judged, because there are so many believers here. That's a dangerous error in thinking. Just as Achan's sin negatively affected all of Israel, so the sins of our country will negatively affect all of us here.

I remember my high school football days where this truth was made obvious in almost every practice. I was a misunderstood and under-appreciated lineman, and we had to practice pass protection every practice because our strength as a team was passing. Our coach would play quarterback, and he would have many different defensive setups taking turns rushing the passer. We had to keep him from even being touched for at least three seconds, and we had to do it five times in a row. One guy missing his block meant that the whole line (five guys) ran laps—we were all "punished" (extra running is punishment indeed). I personally don't want to experience God's judgment on our country, and I don't want to have to "run" because I was too proud to admit that I'm part of a unit, and if just one of us fails, we all fail.

Read the prayers of Ezra, Nehemiah, and Daniel (Ezra 9:5-15; Nehemiah 1:4-11; Daniel 9:4-19). These are obviously men of God living for him, and they haven't committed the particular sins that caused God to judge Israel and send them into exile—but notice how these men humble themselves and make statements like these: "Our guilt has reached to the heavens"; "We have forsaken the commands you gave"; "We have acted very wickedly toward you"; "We have not obeyed the laws you gave your servant Moses"; "We have sinned and done wrong"; "We have rebelled against him." They understand corporate responsibility for sin. They knew they were Jews, and since the Jewish nation had sinned and they were part of that nation, they shared in bearing the national responsibility.

Do we understand that about ourselves? It requires real humility to acknowledge that we've sinned just because we're Americans. Are we will-

ing to begin our prayers (as these men did) with this acknowledgment: "We have sinned"?

It's not only the sin of America that we need to confess, but also the sin of the church. We may be involved in a dynamic life-changing ministry that's being used by God to make a difference in the world. We may have been living sacrificially in response to God's call on our life, and like Daniel, Ezra, and Nehemiah, we're trying hard to honor the name of God in the way we live and treat other people. We, as an individual, can be doing everything right. But since the church for the most part has been sitting in the stands and not playing on the field, we have sinned.

Again, real humility is necessary to be able to pray like this, especially if we're serving in our local church by using our spiritual gifts and giving sacrificially and in general trying to honor God in all aspects of our lives. In such an individualistic culture like ours, it's hard for anyone—even believers—to grasp this truth. But the church must get this if we want to make a difference in our culture.

Again, are we willing to begin our prayers with, "We have sinned as a church..."?

We also need to seriously reconsider *what* we pray for.

14

A New Old Way to Pray

This, then, is how you should pray.

Matthew 6:9

The most famous prayer in the Bible is what's known as the Lord's Prayer. We find the longer version of it in Matthew 6 and a shorter version in Luke 11. Jesus teaches us how to pray on these two different occasions, once as part of his famous Sermon on the Mount, and another time when the disciples specifically ask him to teach them how to pray.

One would think that given clear instructions on how to pray, the church would always follow these carefully. But we have not. Many of us learned the Lord's Prayer just by praying it in church every week, but that doesn't mean we actually pray the way Jesus taught us to pray.

A phrase-by-phrase examination of this prayer, as compared with the average believer's prayer requests and way of praying, should demonstrate my point. I confess that I don't know what the average believer prays in private, but if our public prayers are any indication, we have some work to do.

"***Our Father in heaven***"—I believe we've forgotten, or have maybe taken for granted, how amazing it is that we can call God our Father. I think we must begin our prayers with thanksgiving and praise and wonder that we can call God our Father. Everything else in the prayer flows from that. How do we describe the greatness of God? Do we look at the burning bush in Exodus 3, or Isaiah's commission in Isaiah 6, or Ezekiel's visions in Ezekiel 1, where the glory of God instantly put these men on their faces? How about those throne room scenes throughout Revelation? Maybe we could reflect on what happened at Sodom and

Gomorrah in Genesis 19, or on God's response to the rebellion of Korah and friends in Numbers 16. We could explore his wrath against the two sons of Aaron (Leviticus 10) and later against Uzzah (2 Samuel 6), when certain men presumptively took lightly the holiness of God and paid for it with their lives.

The truth that God spoke this world into existence (Genesis 1:3; Psalm 33:6-9; Hebrews 11:3) and that all life is sustained by his word (Colossians 1:17; Hebrews 1:3) should surely give us pause. The dependent creation which is marred by sin still gloriously proclaims God's "eternal power and divine nature" (Romans 1:20). I cannot imagine how glorious this creation was before mankind's fall. Human beings had the audacity to believe the lies of the devil instead of the living words of God, and brought sin into his perfect world to totally infect both our environment and ourselves.

Isaiah tells us that our "righteous deeds are as filthy rags" to our holy God. The Hebrew term for filthy rags is the word for a menstrual cloth. It's a sickening and disgusting picture of how God views even the good things we do. Yet someone how this God wants the people who messed up his perfect creation to be able to call him Father. He wants this so much that he was willing to send his one and only Son—who was willing to go—into this cesspool of sin for the specific task of being punished in our place for our sin, so he could forgive us and have us live with him forever. This is love beyond human comprehension!

Paul prays for the Ephesians to have the power "to grasp how wide and long and high and deep is the love of Christ, and to know this love that *surpasses knowledge*" (Ephesians 3:18-19). This prayer tells us that the love of God for us is so great that we'll be amazed by it throughout all eternity, as we learn more and more of its greatness.

We can call God "Father" because of all the great things that happened on the cross. Words like justification, reconciliation, propitiation,

adoption, and redemption are words that tell us what God accomplished in and through Jesus so that we could be forgiven and live with him forever.

God not only makes us part of his family, thus tying his reputation to us; he also makes us "joint heirs with Christ" (Romans 8:17), and he considers us to be his inheritance (Ephesians 1:18). Isaiah 55:8-9 reminds us how far above human thinking or human reason are God's ways and God's thinking, which I'm sure all of us can heartily agree with. God's thinking is so far above ours that there's really no comparison; this is demonstrated clearly by God's willingness to have mercy on us and to "freely pardon" (55:6-7).

This has to mean that no human being, under any circumstances, would ever have thought of the cross. It's a totally foreign concept, something we cannot conceive of for any reason. How then can we ever be so casual when we talk about Jesus dying for us? Why do we act as if it's just another thing that has happened, pretty important, but just another event? Where is the awe and wonder when we talk about or think about the cross? That the God of the universe made it possible for us to call him Father should be the most astounding idea of all time. I believe it should automatically cause us to want to demonstrate his greatness to everyone around us. Realizing that we can call the God of heaven our Father should bring from our hearts and lips a natural flow of glorifying his name and making his name special.

"***Hallowed be your name***"—I suspect that the only time most of us ever say "hallowed" is when we recite the Lord's Prayer. It sounds so spiritual, so holy. Yet the idea is fairly simple. It just means to make God look good, which actually is holy and spiritual. And not just good—he looks amazing, he looks great; adequate words to describe his greatness are hard to come by.

I think it's a natural progression that as we call God our Father in heaven, we should naturally want to live our lives in such a way that he is honored, and other people are compelled to realize how great he is. Matthew 5:16 speaks of our light shining through our good works so that our Father in heaven receives glory. Are we consciously and regularly asking God to glorify himself through our lives?

The Westminster Catechism says that mankind's chief end is to glorify God. Is our own chief goal in life to bring glory to our Father in heaven? In Isaiah 26:8 we read, "Yes, Lord, walking in the way of your laws, we wait for you; your name and renown are the desire of our hearts." Is God's reputation the desire of *our* hearts?

Jesus is teaching us here that the first thing we should be asking for when we pray is that the name of our Father in heaven would be glorified, made much of, exalted, etc. Is that the first thing we ask God for when we begin our prayers? Jesus put this first; how about us?

Remember that Jesus introduced the famous Lord's Prayer by saying, "This then is how you should pray." *Is* this how we pray? Do we begin our prayers by asking that God's name would be glorified in and through us?

When people ask how to pray for you, how often do you tell them, "Please pray that God would be glorified in my life"? I'm fairly certain that this is a prayer God wants to answer with a big YES. This truth seems so obvious. Yet I suspect that most of us in our prayers tend to focus just on the things that are impacting our lives, instead of what is most important to God.

I remember when this truth first jumped out at me. The sad truth is that I'd been in the pastoral ministry for a number of years already, and had read and said the Lord's Prayer multiple times, and had already read many times the text in Exodus that God used to show me this. I was

once again reading about the golden calf debacle in Exodus 32 when I first realized how prayer that focuses on God's glory actually accomplishes some amazing things. As the people below descended wildly into idolatry, God told Moses to leave him alone, "so that my anger may burn against them and that I may destroy them. Then I will make you into a great nation" (32:10). The scary thing is that God was willing to disown these people and start all over again with Moses. God was perfectly willing to flush four hundred years of work down the toilet and start all over again with Moses.

Moses's prayer in response is instructive about the kind of praying that grabs God's attention. Moses reminded God of three things.

First, these were God's people whom God himself brought up out of Egypt (32:11).

Second, if God did destroy this people, the Egyptians would say that God was really bad because his intent all along was only to bring them into the wilderness "to wipe them off the face of the earth" (32:12).

Third, Moses prayed, "Remember your promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, to whom you swore by your own self" (10:13).

The reminder that stood out to me was Moses insisting that God's reputation was at stake. Basically Moses was telling God that he would look really bad in the eyes of the Egyptians if he destroyed Israel. Now it's true that God isn't bothered even one little bit about what anyone, let alone the Egyptians, think about what he's going to do or what he has done. What impressed God was that Moses understood that God's glory was paramount. God would have been totally within his character to completely destroy those people and start all over with Moses, and this would not have altered his promise to Abraham, Isaac, and Israel at all. The one thing that moved God was Moses's great understanding that God's glory and honor were the most important thing.

We see the same thing in another passage we also looked at earlier—Numbers 14, where the people refused to trust God and go up and take the Promised Land after ten of their spies gave a negative report. Again God was more than upset, and again he said he was going to kill them all and start over with Moses. Again Moses prayed, and this time he focused totally on what the Egyptians would think of God if he actually did destroy the whole lot of them and start over with Moses.

Amazingly, Moses basically tells God (in Numbers 14:13-16) that if God did what he said he wanted to do, both the Egyptians and the Canaanites would mock him. Once again, God did not act based on public opinion polls; he wasn't at all concerned that he might not be liked by someone. God instead was impressed by the fact that Moses understood how important it was for God to be glorified and exalted.

This in no way meant that God has some kind of ego problem where he needs our accolades. Rather, it's we who need to praise and glorify him for our own benefit, and so that others will see the greatness of God and believe.

I'll give you another example of someone who understood how important God's reputation is. It's the prayer in Daniel 9—when Daniel realized from his reading of Scripture that Jerusalem's destruction would last for seventy years. This passage is instructive in how we should pray when God's people are in trouble. Listen to Daniel as he addresses God: "Now Lord...who made for *yourself* a name that endures to this day"; Daniel speaks of "*your* city, *your* holy hill," "*your* people," "for *your* sake, Lord," "the city that bears *your* name"; again he tells God that his petition is "for *your* sake...because *your* city and *your* people bear *your* Name." Do we hear this clearly? Daniel is reminding God that *His* reputation is on the line. He understands that God's glory is so important.

These are the kind of prayers that move God, that change him from legitimately desiring to destroy people to changing his mind (*not* his essential character) and allowing the people to live.

I wonder if the church in America understands the vital importance of glorifying God, and the power of prayers that focus on God's glory. Sadly, I don't think we do. I think our prayer requests indicate that we're more interested in personal well-being rather than in the glory of the one who forgave all our sins through the death of his Son, so we could have the astounding privilege of calling him our Father in heaven. Will we boldly ask God to glorify himself through his church, the people who bear his name? Will we remind him that even though we've done a really poor job of representing him, most of the world considers us a Christian country, so his reputation is tied to us? Can we demonstrate to God through our prayers that we realize how important it is that his name should be exalted and glorified?

"***Your kingdom come, your will be done on earth as it is in heaven***"—I believe these two phrases of the Lord's Prayer tell us how we go about glorifying God on a daily basis. I think it can be effectively argued that this reference to God's kingdom and God's will can refer to Christ's return and reign on earth, and we certainly should be praying for that. But I also think it can refer to evangelism and to ordinary, everyday obedience to God.

God's kingdom is "already and not yet," as many theologians have stated. It is "already" in the sense that God rules in the hearts of all believers everywhere; so when we pray, "Your kingdom come," we can and should be asking God to help us win the lost to faith in Christ. Every time someone believes, God's kingdom is expanded, and clearly this is a good thing.

While we eagerly and expectantly await and pray for Christ's return, are we asking God to help us glorify his name by using us to share the

gospel? Jesus told us, "The harvest is plentiful but the workers are few. Ask the Lord of the harvest, therefore, to send out workers into his harvest field" (Matthew 9:37). Do we see where we live and work as opportunities to serve others, so we can earn the right to tell them about Jesus?

The second thing Jesus taught us to pray for, after glorifying God, was that his kingdom would come. God has given every believer the job of telling others about Jesus, so we should be praying that God would give us opportunities and courage and boldness to tell others about him.

The next phrase— "*Your will be done on earth as it is in heaven*"—is picturesque. Imagine for a minute the throne room of heaven, and God asking Gabriel or Michael or any of the other angels to go to earth and do whatever it is that God wants done. I wonder if any of these angels would say, "I'm too busy right now, I'll get to it later." Or, "I'm not sure I really want to do that, God; why should I?" Or, "What if someone thinks I'm weird or makes fun of me?" Or, "I have some angel friends from the third heaven visiting me, so I'm not available right now." Or think of the other countless excuses we tend to use when God asks us to do something. I'm fairly certain that the answer from heaven's angels is more like "Yes Sir, I'm on it."

I was raised by a father who believed that when he told me or any of my siblings to jump, we should be asking how high on the way up. Somehow I don't think God is a lot different from my father when it comes to his expectations of obedience. I just cannot imagine any of the heavenly beings arguing with God when he asks them to do something. I *can* imagine doing this myself, because I *have* done it—and I doubt I'm much different in that from my other brothers and sisters in Christ. That certainly doesn't make it okay, and I know that no follower of Jesus would ever argue that it's okay. Are we praying that we would obey

God here on earth as promptly and fully as all the heavenly beings obey God in heaven?

Again, Jesus taught us what to pray for: first, that God would be glorified; second, that his kingdom would come (evangelism); and third, that we would obey without question. When was the last time any of us mentioned these things when someone asked us, "What can I pray for you?" Are these things on the prayer lists of our small groups?

"Give us today our daily bread." This is the part of the Lord's Prayer that we're very good at. Obviously its primary focus is the stuff we need to live, but I think it would also include all those things we regularly deal with—jobs, sicknesses (ours and others), family situations, etc. Jesus makes it clear that he really cares about everything that's going on in our lives, so it's certainly legitimate to bring them before him in prayer and to ask others to pray for these things as well.

"And forgive us our debts as we have forgiven our debtors." This is a very significant prayer. Jesus' little commentary at the end of this prayer (in Matthew 6:14-15) make it clear that forgiving others is something Christians will do, for to not forgive is to not be a Christian. I think this request has to do with our relationships with other people, in particular our brothers and sisters in Christ. (We'll look more at this later.)

"And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from the evil one." I think the focus here is on our personal struggle with the flesh. We should also be praying that God would not be dishonored by our lives. In Psalm 69:6, David prays, "Lord, the Lord Almighty, may those who hope in you not be disgraced because of me; God of Israel, may those who seek you not be put to shame because of me." Do we ask God to protect us from ourselves and from Satan? Do we ask God to guard us from any circumstances which he knows would bring us down? The church is regularly accused of being full of hypocrites. Are we asking God to help us so that no one will say we are one of those hypocrites?

Jesus told us to pray on all these things—so why are we mostly focusing on "our daily bread," and rarely if ever focusing on God's glory, or his kingdom, or obedience, or getting along with other believers, or winning the war with the flesh?

We also tend to ignore other prayers in the New Testament which, it seems clear to me, we should be praying for our churches.

15

Pray Like Paul

Devote yourselves to prayer,

being watchful and thankful.

Colossians 4:2

God gave us clear direction for what to pray not only in the Lord's Prayer, but also throughout the rest of the New Testament. I'd read Paul's letters to the various churches many times and therefore read the things he prayed for them, but it never dawned on me that these were models for prayer given to us by God. I read D. A. Carson's book *Praying with Paul: A Call to Spiritual Reformation*, which really challenged me to start praying with Paul. I realized that Paul's prayers, since they're written down in the New Testament, are inspired by God, and therefore are divine instruction about how to pray for the church and for any brother or sister in Christ. Paul commands us to "devote" ourselves to prayer, so it seems to me that God expects us to be disciplined not only in praying, but in what we pray for.

Do we regularly give thanks to God for the church we are part of? (Ephesians 1:15; 1 Thessalonians 1:2; 2 Thessalonians 1:3). How about asking God to help us comprehend and know the love of Christ "that surpasses knowledge" (Ephesians 3:18-19)? It would be helpful if our relationship with God was always grounded in faith and God's unconditional love and acceptance for us in Christ (Ephesians 3:17). Just think how our churches would be revolutionized if we truly grasped the hope of our calling and at the same time understood that God considers us his glorious inheritance (Ephesians 1:18). And there's so much more to learn from Paul's prayers. These concepts are mind-boggling and as we pray them we cannot help but love God more and want to

serve him more. I think that we've been missing out on some really amazing answers to prayer because we've largely ignored the clear instructions that God has given us on what to pray for.

One might have the impression that I look down on the kinds of things that are prayed for most often—a family member going through problems of some kind, a sick friend, a struggling marriage, etc. But that would be a wrong impression. In the two small Bible study groups I participate in, we regularly pray for many different items that group members share about each week. Jesus clearly cares about these kinds of things and encourages us to pray for them (Matthew 7:7-11). My point is that there are other things that God has clearly told us to pray for, but we've chosen for the most part to focus on what's important to us and not on what's most important for the health of the church. It's the health of the church that is going to change our country so we should be making that our highest priority if we want to build up the wall and stand in the gap.

16

Pray Like Jesus

...so that they may be brought to complete unity.

Then the world will know that you sent me

and have loved them even as you have loved me.

John 17:23

The second most famous prayer in the Bible is probably Jesus' prayer recorded in John 17. This prayer is divided into three parts: Jesus prays for himself (17:1-5), he prays for the disciples (17:6-19), and he's praying for the church (17:20-26).

The church's practice with this prayer is much like it has been with the Lord's Prayer. It truly baffles me that rarely do we hear believers request unity as one of their prayer requests, yet that's what Jesus prayed for us. Could it be that we rarely think about the church as a whole because we're so individualistic?

We've seen the power and importance of loving one another. Probably the greatest evidence that we do love one another is unity. Twice in John 17 Jesus prays for our unity while mentioning the impact this will have on people around us:

> I pray also for those who will believe in me... through their message, that all of them may be one, Father, just as you are in me and I am in you. May they also be in us so that the world may believe that you have sent me. (17:20-21)

> May they be brought to complete unity to let the world know that you sent me and have loved them even as you have loved me. (17:23)

Unity tells the world (which refers to all those who are opposed to Jesus) that God sent his Son into the world, and that God loves them—the world—as much as he loves Jesus. Not only does loving one another show people that we are disciples of Jesus (John 13:34-35), as well as showing people God (1 John 4:12); it also is the greatest apologetic we have for the truth that Jesus came from God and that God really does love the world. This tells me that we don't have to be able to answer every hard question that an unbeliever might ask; rather, the truth of the gospel is shown by how we believers treat each other and work together for God's glory.

Unity—the result of loving and serving one another—is one of the main themes of Paul's letters to the churches. Most of the chapters in Paul's first letter to the church at Corinth deal with issues that have divided this church. In the letter's first four chapters, we see Paul addressing how the Corinthians were boasting about the superiority of their preferred spiritual leaders. He begins this section with a plea: "that all of you agree with one another in what you say and that there be no divisions among you, but that you be perfectly united in mind and thought" (1:10).

Throughout these chapters, notice how Paul points them to Jesus and God and away from themselves:

> Let the one who boasts boast in the Lord. (1:31)
>
> I resolved to know nothing while I was with you except Jesus Christ and him crucified. (2:2)
>
> What, after all, is Apollos? And what is Paul? Only servants, through whom you came to believe—as the Lord has assigned to each his task. I planted the seed, Apollos watered it, but God has been making it grow. So neither the one who plants nor the one who waters is anything, but only

> God, who makes things grow. The one who plants and the one who waters have one purpose, and they will each be rewarded according to their own labor. For we are co-workers in God's service; you are God's field, God's building. (1 Corinthians 3:5-9)

Paul also tells them that division is a sign of immaturity and worldliness (3:1-4).

We learn from Paul in chapter 6 that the Corinthian believers have been taking each other to court. Paul is shocked by this; they should know that they will one day be judging angels (6:3), so why aren't they taking their disputes before the church instead? He says that having lawsuits among them shows that they've been "completely defeated" (6:7). Paul then asks a question that goes totally against everything we Americans have been taught: "Why not rather be wronged? Why not rather be cheated?" (6:7). Can we even imagine the average American Christian practicing this kind of selflessness regarding what they consider important beliefs and traditions and programs and music styles and architecture and so many other things that we fight and divide over? Do we understand that when we quarrel and dispute with each other in such a way that it becomes public knowledge, we've already been defeated, and Satan has won a victory?

In chapters 8-10 of 1 Corinthians, Paul speaks to the issue of how we use our freedom in Christ in relating to our brothers and sisters in Christ. The particular issue is whether it's acceptable to eat meat previously offered to idols. The issue of "rights" comes up often in this discussion. Paul cautions them: "Be careful...that the exercise of your rights does not become a stumbling block to the weak" (8:9).

Chapter 9 is an extended argument from Paul about how he gave up his rights for the sake of the gospel. Repeatedly he speaks of "rights" that he himself certainly has, but which he has given up "rather than hin-

der the gospel of Christ" (9:12). "I have not used any of these rights" he states in 9:15, while especially emphasizing his taking no payment for preaching the gospel.

Paul makes a particularly astounding statement in verse 19: "Though I am free and belong to no one, I have made myself a slave to everyone, to win as many as possible." He goes on to give us the reason for this kind of submissive living: "I do all this for the sake of the gospel, that I may share in its blessings" (1 Corinthians 9:23).

Are we, for the sake of the gospel, willing to let our brothers and sisters in Christ be in charge of how things are done in our churches? Are we willing to give up having things our way? I wonder if the church has been so ineffective in influencing our culture because we haven't loved one another, but instead have demanded our rights, thus allowing the world to see us as anything but united for the sake of the gospel.

Probably the best known problem in the Corinthian church is their confusion about spiritual gifts, which Paul deals with in chapters 12–14. The famous love passage (chapter 13) is right in the middle of this section, and once again Paul is teaching that our unity is more important than our individual gifting. Yes, we all have gifts given to us by the Holy Spirit (12:4-11), but we don't operate independently of one another. We're part of a body, and just as in the human body, every part is essential to the proper functioning of the whole, and no one individual is more spiritual than any other.

Paul exhorts them to "follow the way of love" (14:1), which clearly means—from everything he has taught thus far in this letter—to put others' interests ahead of our own. I find it revealing that the believers at Corinth are just like Jesus' disciples—less focused on the gospel than on who among them was greater. Whether it was which spiritual leader they followed was superior, or which of their spiritual gifts made them more spiritual, the ultimate issue was the same: Who is the greatest? I

wonder if the church in America is any different from the disciples and the New Testament church at Corinth.

As we've seen, chapter 2 in Paul's letter to the church at Philippi teaches us that the key to unity is giving up our rights. Let's look at this passage in greater depth. Throughout his letter to the Philippians, Paul shows us the specific commands and Christlike mindset that are required in order to experience unity in our churches. Paul links living a life worthy of the gospel with the commitment to "stand firm in the one Spirit, striving together as one for the faith of the gospel" (1:27). Paul's heart is revealed in 2:1-2, when he states that his joy is made complete when believers are "like-minded, having the same love, being one in spirit and of one mind."

He then gives two commands in verse 3—one telling us what not to do, another telling us what to do. The negative command Paul gives is this: "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit." This is where the desire to be recognized as the greatest comes from. As we've seen, we all struggle a great deal with these issues, probably more than we realize.

The antidote for this is Paul's positive command, which immediately follows: "Value others above yourselves." I think the nasb captures best the idea here: "Let each of you regard one another as more important than himself." We're commanded to make a mental decision that everyone else in the church is more important than we are. Their ideas, their plans, their musical tastes, their ministries—all these are to be considered more important than our own. This elevates humility to a whole new level, one that's uncomfortable to most of us.

Paul then expands on these commands: "Do not merely look out for your own personal interests, but also for the interests of others" (2:4 nasb). Can we even imagine what this must look like? One person presents their idea, then someone else presents their different idea, and in the ensuing discussion the first person promotes and argues for the sec-

ond person's idea instead of his own. The second person, meanwhile, is arguing for the first person's idea. The overall concept here is that as we put others' interests ahead of our own, they also are putting our interests ahead of theirs.

Again we have to make a mental decision. Now we're seeing what Paul meant in Romans 12:2 when he told us to not be conformed to this world, "but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what God's will is—his good, pleasing and perfect will." We all want to know the perfect will of God. Well, here it is, plain and simple, yet so costly: We need to think about others the same way Jesus thought about us, and do the same kind of thing for others that Jesus did for us.

Jesus' thought process, which we're to emulate, is laid out for us in Philippians 2:6-8. The basic message here, I believe, is that Jesus gave up his rights so we could have something that we didn't even deserve. This text tells us how far we must be willing to go in giving up our rights. And honestly, it's scary. Basically, believers have *no* rights. This goes against everything we Americans value so highly, but this is what is supposed to define the church.

How can we do such a thing? We can do it because God has our back. Romans 8 is an amazing passage that tells us that God truly and certainly is on our side. "If God is for us, who can be against us? He who did not spare his own Son, but gave him up for us all—how will he not also, along with him, graciously give us all things?" (8:31-32). We give our rights up, and God gives them back.

Listen to Philippians 2:9-11, showing what God has done because Jesus gave up his rights for our benefit:

> Therefore God exalted him to the highest place and gave him the name that is above every name, that at the name

> of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue acknowledge that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

God takes care of our rights for us. God exalts us when we humble ourselves and make others more important than ourselves. What an amazing truth! We're really giving up nothing, because God takes care of us beyond what we can imagine.

Peter reminds us that God does this in his own way and in his own time (1 Peter 5:6). Peter then acknowledges that living this way can create anxiety, so all we have to do is tell God about our anxiety, and he will remind us that he cares for us. He who sent his Son to die even cares about our rights. Amazing!

We will never give up as much as Jesus gave up, but by God's grace, we can decide to think like Jesus thought; we can decide that others are more important than ourselves, and then live that out—because the gospel is more important than our rights, and God's kingdom is greater than our rights, and God has our back.

One of the greatest examples of what this might look like is found in the Old Testament. It's the story of Abram and his nephew Lot. As nearly as we can tell, Lot's father had died, so Abram took Lot in and raised him,

Genesis 13 relates the story about how and why Lot ended up in Sodom. God had greatly blessed Abram (13:2), and because Lot's wagon was hitched to Abram, Lot also became quite wealthy in flocks and herds. The result was that the area where they lived could not support both men's flocks and herds. We would expect Abram—because he raised Lot, and because Lot's success was due to Abram—to have first choice to take the land he wanted and let Lot have the leftovers. Obviously this was Abram's right; in that culture especially, the father

took precedence over the son (or nephew, in this case). Abram surprises us by giving Lot the first choice; whatever Lot didn't take would go to Abram.

Abram's reason for doing this is so relevant to the church today. Listen to Abram: "Let's not have any quarreling between you and me, or between your herders and mine, for we are close relatives" (13:8). Abram does exactly what Paul is calling us to do in Philippians 2. He gives up his rights and considers Lot to be more important than himself. The result is peace.

It would seem that this decision was costly for Abram, because Lot looked around and took the Jordan River valley, which had the best water and pasture. Abram appeared to receive the short end of the stick. God demonstrated that he had Abram's back by telling Abram to look all around him, because God was giving to him and his descendants everything Abram could see (which would include the Jordan River valley).

When we give up our rights for the sake of peace in the church and the truth of the gospel, God sees, and God blesses.

This is what it takes to have unity in our local churches. Unity is what Jesus prayed for the church. Unity is what tells the world that Jesus came from God and that God loves us as much as he loves Jesus.

Are we praying for unity in our church? Are we asking God where we need to give up our rights for the sake of unity and the gospel?

17

Forgive Like Jesus

Bear with each other and forgive one another

if any of you has a grievance against someone.

Forgive as the Lord forgave you.

Colossians 3:13

Unity is a powerful truth, but there's a big problem with unity. The people we're supposed to be unified with are just like us. We all find it difficult to love others as we love ourselves, so our biggest struggle is self-centeredness. It's hard to be unified with people who are just as self-centered as we are. Yet unity is what God expects of us.

In Colossians 3:13 (quoted above), we're told what we must do in order to have the unity Jesus is speaking of. It's interesting that this verse actually modifies or explains a previous command given in verse 12. That verse explains how we're to dress ourselves—not with clothing, but with character. The command is this: "Clothe yourselves with compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, and patience."

Each of these words, in this context, implies that our brothers and sisters in Christ will sometimes be hard to get along with, let alone be unified with. The only way we can clothe ourselves with these characteristics is to bear with one another and forgive one another. The word for "bear with" means "to endure" something—in this case, a fellow believer. This means there will be times in the church where we have to suck it up and patiently and humbly endure another believer. The other side of this coin is a little bit harder to swallow. Other believers are going to have to patiently and humbly endure *me*.

Yes, people who've been born again—and who therefore have a brand new nature, and have the Holy Spirit living in them, and who are really trying to serve God—will still struggle with the one sin most devastating to unity: self-centeredness. All of us fit this category, and the sooner we own up to it, the more we'll actually be able to have victory personally and corporately.

There's absolutely no excuse for being self-centered, or for committing any other sin for that matter. We have a new nature, we have the Holy Spirit indwelling us, we have God's guarantee of heaven. So one would think we should never sin. But we all know too well that our flesh fights hard against everything God has done for us in Christ, and more times than we like to admit, the flesh wins (Romans 7:13-25). I believe that acknowledging this reality, and not being shocked when another believer hurts us personally or hurts another person, will go a long way toward having the kind of unity Jesus prayed for.

Whenever we say, "I can't believe they did that!" or, "How could they say something like that?" we're making two mistakes. First, we're forgetting that we're quite capable of doing the exact same thing. (Remembering this will help keep us humble). And second, we're actually judging the other person, which according to Jesus in Matthew 7:3-5 is a greater sin.

It's much easier to bear with one another when we recall that we, too, struggle with sin in general and with self-centeredness in particular. This should help us have compassion, humility, and patience when bearing with our fellow believers.

Just bearing with one another is not enough; we must also let the sin go and be willing to have a relationship with those who have sinned against us. We need to forgive each other just as Jesus forgave us (Colossians 3:13). Forgiveness is a divine attribute, and only believers can forgive in the same way Jesus did. And the hard truth is that if we're un-

willing to forgive, then we're most likely *not* a believer. Jesus makes this clear in his commentary on his prayer in Matthew 6:14-15, and in his discussion with Peter about forgiveness in Matthew 18:21-35.

"Forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors"—this part of the Lord's Prayer doesn't get enough attention. I think that's because we don't want to face up to the truth of what Jesus is saying here. This is the only phrase from the Lord's Prayer that Jesus actually has commentary on. Verses 14-15 are that commentary, where Jesus says clearly, "If you do not forgive others their sins, your Father will not forgive your sins" (6:15). I don't think this means our forgiveness is conditional. Rather, I think Jesus is simply saying that true believers forgive.

The forgiveness the Bible teaches is an attribute of God, and only those who have the Holy Spirit living in them can forgive the way God does. We need to remember that when God forgives us, it's not just so we don't have to go to hell, but that we also now are guaranteed a place in God's home in heaven. *Forgiveness means relationship*. We cannot say that we forgive someone if we're not willing to be in relationship with them.

In Matthew 18:21, Peter asks Jesus how many times he must forgive someone when they sin against him. Peter suggests, "Up to seven times?" The rabbis taught only three times, so Peter thinks he has been paying attention, and that to forgive someone seven times is really above and beyond the call of duty. Once again, Jesus shocks us with his answer: "Seventy-seven times" (or "seventy times seven," in the niv marginal reading). The point Jesus is making is that there's to be no limit on forgiveness.

Luke 17:4 records another occasion when Jesus teaches on this without being asked anything by the disciples. Jesus says, "Even if they sin against you seven times in a day and seven times come back to you say-

ing, 'I repent,' you must forgive them." (He must have been thinking about wives dealing with their husbands.)

Jesus goes on to tell Peter a parable that explains why we can forgive. He tells about a man who owed his king an impossible amount to pay back, and how the king graciously forgave the entire debt when the man begged the king to give him a chance to pay it back. The king knew it was impossible for the man to ever pay off this debt. This sounds a lot like God with our sins. It's impossible for us to earn forgiveness, so God graciously forgives us because of the work of Christ on the cross.

In the parable, this man who had just received a gift beyond human understanding went out and refused to forgive the debt of a man who owed him a very small amount. The point of this parable is that the amount of sin God forgives each of us (all sin; past, present, and future) is so much greater than any sin or sins that any human would ever commit against us. This means that if we refuse to forgive our brothers and sisters, we make ourselves bigger than God. This is obviously not a smart thing to do.

Jesus tells us that when this man's master heard about how the man had refused to forgive the small debt, the king "handed him over to the jailers to be tortured, until he should pay back all he owed" (Matthew 18:34). Jesus wraps up this parable by stating, "This is how my heavenly Father will treat each of you unless you forgive your brother or sister from your heart" (18:35).

The lesson in all this is that believers will forgive one another because in Christ, God has forgiven us. And the amount of sin God has forgiven us is much greater than any sin any human can commit against us in this life.

Looking again at Colossians 3, I think it's interesting what Paul says next, in 3:14— "And over all these virtues put on love, which binds

them all together in perfect unity." Paul then says, "Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, since as members of one body you were called to peace" (3:15). The peace he's speaking of here is not some warm fuzzy feeling of well-being. It's the truth that because Christ took God's righteous wrath upon himself, we are at peace with God and part of one body, for we have been called to peace. Loving one another, serving one another, forgiving one another is possible because we are at peace with God.

There are three truths that have helped me a great deal in trying to live this out.

The first truth is that I'm no better than anyone else. Given the right set of circumstances, I could commit the same sin the other person has committed.

I remember how I used to be amazed at all the dumb stuff the Jews did on their way out of Egypt to the Promised Land. How could they not trust God when they had seen all those miracles? They had the pillar of smoke by day and the pillar of fire by night. How could they not trust God? In 1 Corinthians 10:11-12, Paul tells us that all those dumb things were written down "as warnings to us... So, if you think you are standing firm, be careful that you don't fall!"

Guess what! We are just as dumb as they were, and if we're honest with ourselves, we can easily understand why they did what they did. We've already decided that we're no better than the disciples, so that means we all struggle with sin (1 Corinthians 10:13), and since they were a fairly selfish lot, we must be too—so we should be able to cut each other a lot of slack.

It's also helpful to remember Jesus' teaching in Matthew 7:1-5 about not judging other believers. Judging is when a person views himself as above and better than someone else who's being irritating or otherwise

misbehaving. Jesus is clear that this sin of judging is worse than whatever sin the other person is doing.

It always makes me nervous when I hear believers say, "I would never do that." First, it is judging. Second, it removes our first line of defense against a particular sin, the reality that given the right circumstances we can do pretty much anything. It prevents us from seeing the temptation for what it is, and then we're in trouble. The reality of our own sinfulness should make us compassionate toward our brothers and sisters in Christ when they sin against us.

The second helpful truth I've seen, and which we must always remind ourselves, is how God views that brother or sister in Christ. Our standing with God because of what Christ did for us on the cross is absolutely mind-boggling. In Romans 8:1-2, Paul tells us that God no longer condemns us because we are in Christ. In Galatians 3:26, he says we are "clothed with Christ." God sees all the righteousness and holiness of Jesus when he looks at us. In Ephesians 1:18 we read that we are God's glorious inheritance.

This book isn't long enough to begin to cover the amazing love that God has for us in Christ. These truths are what enable us to get victory over sin. They're the truths that motivate us to serve God. We love him because he first loved us (1 John 4:10). We serve not out of fear, but out of glorious gratitude for what we have in Christ. We should glory in these truths for ourselves, which is powerful and life-changing, while also remembering that these truths also apply to that brother or sister who irritates us or who has sinned against us. God has already forgiven them, and they're loved by God as much as he loves us. This means that if God doesn't condemn them, if he accepts them totally and completely—then who are we to treat them any differently?

The third helpful truth is something we've already considered, when Jesus answered Peter about whether to forgive someone more than seven

times. I find it very humbling to remind myself that God has forgiven me much more (all of my sin; past, present, and future) than he is asking me to forgive someone else who sins against me. Certainly it's very hard sometimes to forgive, but Jesus makes it clear that we must forgive each other—and by the power of the Holy Spirit, believers will accomplish this divine work. Only believers can forgive others the way Christ forgave them. This kind of forgiveness is powerful, and shows the world that we belong to Jesus.

18

Yes, We Have to Do Evangelism

We are therefore Christ's ambassadors,

as though God were making his appeal through us.

We implore you on Christ's behalf:

Be reconciled to God.

2 Corinthians 5:20

The next area I believe the church needs to seriously work on is evangelism. For many of us, evangelism is one of the scariest words we can hear. We know it's good news about Jesus, but it seems to be bad news about what God expects of us. I can remember thinking that it would be much more effective if God would just send angels to tell unbelievers about Jesus. An angelic messenger would be an attention-grabber for sure! The problem is, God must not think so. God believes that the best way to communicate the gospel is for forgiven sinners to tell unforgiven sinners that Jesus wants to forgive them. Most of us think that this plan is decidedly *not* good news.

We're a lot like the prophet Jonah. As we recall, God wanted him to do evangelism in Nineveh, but Jonah didn't want to, so he tried to run from God. I think many of us are running from God because he wants us to do evangelism. We're mostly afraid to even do evangelism. Jonah at least was not afraid of telling them about God; his fear was that they would actually repent and be saved. Just maybe we can quit running and be obedient, and even if we're like Jonah and our heart isn't in it, the power of the message backed by the working of the Holy Spirit might just cause an entire country to repent.

One of the biggest deterrents to evangelism is the *gift* of evangelism. We hear stories from people with the gift of evangelism about how they're winning people to Christ and how excited they are to share Christ with just about anyone. A gentleman and his wife who are part of a Bible study group my wife and I attend clearly have the gift of evangelism. It doesn't matter where they are or who they meet, they're always thinking about how to gain an opportunity to tell others about Jesus. They see every encounter with another person as a potential opportunity to share Jesus. They're not rude, and they certainly don't cram Jesus down people's throats; they're just always seeking the opportunity to graciously tell others about Jesus. They're amazing. They see evangelism as fun and exciting.

Then there's the rest of us, who tend to make two big mistakes. First, we think we have to be like those gifted evangelists, and since we aren't—and we realize we probably never will be—we decide we cannot do it, so we just pass, and then feel guilty. Our second mistake is that we keep comparing ourselves to gifted evangelists, and we decide that they're more spiritual than we are, which further reinforces our unworthiness to talk about Jesus anyway. Both of these mistakes are based on the sin—yes, *sin*—of comparison.

Comparison is not inherently sinful. We are told in the book of Hebrews "to imitate those who through faith and patience inherit what has been promised" (Hebrews 6:12). There's nothing wrong with imitating the faith of others that we admire and respect. Comparison becomes sin when we decide that we aren't as good or spiritual as another believer because we can't do the things they do, or don't experience the results they experience.

The gift of evangelism is a primary example. A person with this gift has a special ability given to them by God to tell others about Jesus, and God doesn't expect us to be like them. Paul is helpful here when

he tells us that the only thing God requires of us is faithfulness to the trust we've been given by God. He goes on to say, "I care very little if I am judged by you or by any human court; indeed, I do not even judge myself (1 Corinthians 4:3). All God expects from every believer is that they're faithful in what God has equipped them to do and be. This certainly means that we should know and use our spiritual gift, but it doesn't mean we should be like others who have different gifts than we do.

This doesn't in any way let us off the hook when it comes to evangelism. Jesus is clear about that in the Great Commission passages. This means therefore that we're supposed to be faithful in doing evangelism. What does that look like?

I think the minimum must be a willingness to invite someone to hear about Jesus. This can be a regular service at church, which most certainly should regularly preach the gospel, or a special evangelistic event (like those put on by the Billy Graham Evangelistic Association), or any other event large or small where the gospel is clearly presented. This approach has been called Come-and-See evangelism. It's much like what Andrew did when he invited his brother Simon Peter to come and see the Messiah (John 1:40-42). After such an event where we've invited others, we must be willing to ask them what they thought of the message, and be prepared to explain the gospel to them.

Every follower of Jesus should be able to clearly explain the gospel and to tell why and how they themselves became a believer. It's not enough to live a good life and salve our conscience by saying, "My life is my witness." The gospel must be spoken, and the clear command of Jesus is that all believers are to speak it. Romans 10:14-15 is clear that people cannot believe unless someone speaks the gospel to them. The tragedy of this passage is that the Greek word translated "preacher" and "preach" in most versions gives too many believers the excuse that it

doesn't apply to them, since they aren't a preacher; we conclude that it's primarily the clergy's responsibility to tell others about Jesus. This is absolutely wrong thinking. The word basically means to proclaim something, so it applies to all of us, not just to clergy. Our excuses for not talking to others about Jesus are generally used to cover up our fear.

There are three fears I often hear about that I believe most of us not having the gift of evangelism can relate to. The fear that especially reveals how far we have to go in putting other people's interests (in this case, the interests of unbelievers) before our own is our fear of rejection. It's humbling to realize I might care more about someone not liking me than I do about the fact that they'll go to hell if they don't trust Christ. This fear says a lot about our lack of compassion for those who haven't trusted Jesus.

Another fear is that we won't be able to answer their questions well. Actually this needs to be seen as an opportunity, because in those situations we can and in fact should say, "I don't know the answer to that question, but I'll find out and get back to you." This keeps the door open for further discussion. I've also found that questions are often a means the person uses to deflect the main issue of what they're going to do about their sin. We must be discerning here and be careful not to discount sincere questions. It's also important to remember the truth of John 16:8-11, where Jesus is telling us that whenever we share the gospel with someone, the Holy Spirit is telling them that the sin they really need to worry about is the sin of unbelief, and that they can never be good enough on their own, so they need the righteousness of Jesus—otherwise they stand condemned to hell before the holy God of the universe. They may never physically show that they're being told this by the Holy Spirit, but I think I will take Jesus' word for it.

The last fear is that some of us think our life isn't a good enough testimony, so we feel unqualified or even hypocritical; therefore we don't

share. The first thing we need to realize about this is that Christianity is about forgiveness, not perfection, so being willing to humbly admit we fall short is actually a good thing. Second, why not just clean up our act? If we know of areas of our life that bring shame on the name of our heavenly Father, why aren't we doing something about it?

There's a very helpful book written by Joe Aldrich entitled *Lifestyle Evangelism*. In this book he shows us how we can earn the right to talk to others about Jesus by serving them. God has called us to "do good to all men" (Galatians 6:10), and the parable of the good Samaritan teaches us that we should consider even those who probably hate us to be our neighbor, and therefore we ought to be serving them. There's no better way to earn someone's respect or trust than by serving them. This shows humility and care for our neighbors, and they're much more likely to listen to what we say when we talk to them about Jesus.

The vast majority of us have been placed in situations where we have regular contact and relationships with nonbelievers. There's a reason for this. God wants us to reach those people with the gospel. Those of us who don't have the gift of evangelism (which is most of us) should be regularly praying that God would show us how we can serve the people we come in contact with (especially the regulars) so we can earn the right to tell them about Jesus. We should be looking for opportunities and even create them (Come-and-See evangelism).

Meanwhile, if you *do* have the gift of evangelism—please don't expect the rest of us to be like you, and don't question why we aren't. Keep sharing with us, because your stories are so encouraging and challenging, and we need to hear how God is at work, and we can learn from what you do and how you do it.

Another good book on how those of us who don't have the gift of evangelism can effectively win people to Christ is *The Secret Thoughts of an Unlikely Convert: An English Professor's Journey into Christian Faith*.

The author, Rosaria Champagne Butterfield, relates how she—as a lesbian activist and full professor of English at a major university—came to faith in Christ through a patient, listening, and caring Presbyterian pastor and his wife. For the average Christian who doesn't have the gift of evangelism, this book's first chapter is excellent on how to go about sharing Christ with an unbeliever. As Rosaria tells us about how she viewed Christians, and how this pastor and his wife were so different, and how they served her by listening, understanding, and accepting—yet never abandoning the truth of the gospel—we get a tutorial on how most of us should be doing evangelism. The whole book is a great read, but the first chapter is one of the best stories I've ever read for showing us how we all can be effective witnesses for Christ.

The Moral Majority, Jimmy Carter, Ronald Reagan, the Bushes, and Donald Trump did not change the moral climate in America one iota as far as I can tell. We need to face up to the fact that the government cannot change the hearts and minds of humans. Our government is a reflection of what our overall culture is. I certainly see that we as believers have a responsibility to be involved in the political process and that we're blessed to live in a country where we can be involved both through voting and even holding political office. I'm also thankful for the men and women in our government at all levels who are trying to serve Jesus and represent him well. They have a tough job, and they need and deserve our prayers. I regularly pray that they would be "wise as serpents and innocent as doves" (Matthew 10:16). I also pray that many more like them would be elected to office. Have you noticed though, that even with a victory like the 2022 Supreme Court decision reversing *Roe v. Wade,* a large majority of Americans still support abortion, and greater than 50 percent think this recent decision was wrong. This is a heart issue, and the only thing that can change the human heart is the church preaching and living out the gospel.

19

The Power of Love

No one has ever seen God;

but if we love one another, God lives in us

and his love is made complete in us.

1 John 4:12

It's hard for us to not be self-centered when we don't know that God has forgiven our sins, and that he'll never give up on us, and that he has our back, and he will take care of all of our needs, and he will love us no matter what. Only believers can know all this, and only believers can rise to the level of loving others more than they love themselves. The key to loving others like Jesus expects us to is knowing that God has loved us first.

This brings us right back to the truths we considered as we looked at the Lord's Prayer and spoke of how astounding it is that we can call God our "Father in heaven." The more we understand how amazing our salvation is, the more we'll be able to love others. This might be why Paul prays for the Ephesians in this way:

> I keep asking that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the glorious Father, may give you the Spirit of wisdom and revelation, so that you may know him better. I pray that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened in order that you may know the hope to which he has called you, the riches of his glorious inheritance in his holy people. (Ephesians 1:17-18)

> I pray...that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith. And I pray that you, being rooted and established in love, may have power, together with all the Lord's holy people,

> to grasp how wide and long and high and deep is the love of Christ, and to know this love that surpasses knowledge. (Ephesians 3:16-19)

This might be why Paul spends eleven chapters of the book of Romans focusing on God's grace to us through the work of Christ before he talks about how this grace works out in our daily living. The better we know Jesus and understand what he has done for us through his death and resurrection, the better we will love God, one another, and our neighbor.

Jesus' teaching on what love looks like is clear. The Sermon on the Mount contains some famous verses about "turning the other cheek," "going the extra mile," and "giving up your coat as well" (Matthew 5:38-41). These are all situations where someone is taking advantage of us in the first place, and we're to do more for them than they've even demanded. Jesus then starts to really meddle by telling us it's not enough simply to love our neighbor; we must also love our *enemy* (5:43-44).

The classic and famous parable about loving a neighbor who could very well be our enemy is Jesus' parable about the good Samaritan in Luke 10. Jesus spoke this parable as part of a conversation with an expert in the Old Testament law about what the greatest commandment was. After Jesus affirmed the man's restatement of biblical commands about wholeheartedly loving God and also loving one's neighbor, this man wanted Jesus to explain just exactly who his neighbor would be. The text tells us that his reason for asking Jesus this was that "he wanted to justify himself" (10:29).

This well-known parable is obviously teaching us that anyone we find in need is our neighbor, even if that person hates us. The first two guys who passed the roadside victim (who was probably Jewish) were from the most highly regarded groups in Jewish culture.

Jesus in this parable is pointedly showing us what loving our neighbor looks like. The Samaritan takes care of a person who more than likely would have nothing to do with him if he were healthy. All of us would say that we agree with the teaching of this parable, and I think all of us would say we would have stopped to help the guy. Then why does the church have such a poor reputation in our culture? Surely if we were practicing the truth of this parable, those who are so opposed to what we stand for would think we cared for them rather than looked down on them.

The famous "abiding" passage in John 15 teaches us that to abide ("remain," niv) in Christ means that we're keeping his commands. Too often when we think of Jesus' commands we think of religious activity (the stuff I'll be talking about in later chapters). Jesus tells us, "My command is this; love each other as I have loved you" (John 15:12). Our religious activity is what practicing is to an athletic team. We need to practice. God has given us spiritual disciplines not so we can impress God, but because we need to do them so we can honor God. Athletes practice a lot so that when they compete they can win. We compete in the game of life. Every day we represent Jesus, and without practice, we won't win the game; we won't love each other as Jesus loves us, and the world will fail to learn that Jesus came from God and that God loves them and that we are Jesus' followers.

John must really think love is important because he spends a large portion of his first epistle talking about it. In chapter 2 he tells us, "We know that we have come to know him if we keep his commands" (1 John 2:3). In the next several verses (2:4-11), he tells us that loving our fellow believers is how we demonstrate that we're keeping the Lord's commands. John picks up the theme of loving one another again in 3:14, telling us that we know we have eternal life "because we love one another." Then in 3:16 he explains what love looks like: "This is how we know what love is: Jesus Christ laid down his life for us." Jesus is our

example of what it means to love one another. In the same verse, John adds, "And we ought to lay down our lives for our brothers and sisters." Once more we see that we're to consider the needs of our fellow believers to be more important than our own needs. The practical application John gives here is our being willing to use personal resources, if we have any, to help any fellow Christian in need.

John is still not finished with this teaching. It's almost as if he thinks the church is just like he and the other disciples were when they were with Jesus. He and the other disciples did not grasp it then, so I'm fairly certain John thinks we aren't any more aware than he was. He's therefore going to keep pouring it on. John continues with this theme in chapter 4 and again makes it clear that the kind of love he's talking about comes only from God, and therefore anyone who has been truly "born of God" (4:7) will love. He then talks about what God did to show his love, and John goes into greater detail about this example than he has before. He tells us that God showed his love for us by sending Jesus into the world so we could have life through Jesus. John then reminds us that not only was Jesus sent into the world, but he was sent to experience God's wrath for our sin (4:10). Each time we're told about this kind of love, we're told that we too must love one another in the same way, as in 4:11— "Dear friends, since God so loved us, we also ought to love one another."

Now John makes an amazing statement. He tells us how the world can see God in us; it is by our love for one another. He says no one has ever seen God, but we can show him to the world by our love. We, those who have trusted Christ as our Savior, have the privilege and the power to show God to a lost world (4:12). They do not see God in us because of our church attendance. It is not seeing how I live as an individual, it is observing how I live in interaction with my brothers and sisters in Christ.

We need to pause here and state very clearly three truths that should be very evident to Bible-believing people, but sadly are not.

First, love is not how we feel about one another, but how we treat one another. Our culture has equated "love" with how we feel about someone; our culture tells us that if we really love someone we cannot tell them they're wrong; we must not only accept them but also approve of all their thinking and behavior. This is certainly not what Jesus is talking about when he says we're to love one another.

One of the most famous chapters in the Bible is 1 Corinthians 13, the love chapter, where verses 4-7 define the kind of love God is speaking of when he tells us to love one another. It's clear that love is how we treat one another in spite of how we feel about one another. We don't have to like someone to love them.

Second, "one another" clearly refers to other believers in Christ. Yes, we're to love unbelievers, as the parable of the good Samaritan clearly shows, and I believe that this also shows God's love to the world—but not in the same way that loving each other shows God to the world. Somehow, the way we love our brothers and sisters in the church is the most powerful and effective way we show God to a lost world. The apostle Paul tells us, "Let us do good to all people, especially to those who belong to the family of believers" (Galatians 6:10). Yes, we definitely serve everyone, but our priority is always our brothers and sisters in Christ.

The third point here is that love divorced from truth is just sentimentality. John teaches us in his Gospel that the person of Jesus Christ defines truth (John 14:6). John's first epistle, which so eloquently teaches what it means to love one another, also teaches that if a person has wrong truth about who Christ is, they aren't a believer. In his first epistle, John actually discusses this point just as much as he discusses love. The church must stand for truth and John tells us that wrong teach-

ing on the person of Christ means there can be no love of the kind he's speaking of.

Along with right teaching is right living. The church must uphold the truth that there is right and there is wrong, and God determines what those are. We're called to holy living (1 Peter 1:15-16). We're no longer to live according to the demands of the flesh, but rather to live by the Spirit (Romans 6–8). And part of loving one another is encouraging one another to "love and good works" (Hebrews 10:24), as well as holding each other accountable to holy living (Hebrews 3:13). God expects us to uphold the truth both doctrinally and in our lifestyle as we love one another in a manner that shows God to the world.

Yes, loving one another is challenging, but the results can change a culture. We've seen that when we humble ourselves and give up our rights, God honors that and exalts us (Philippians 2; 1 Peter 5). Jesus tells us that being a servant defines true greatness in the eyes of God (Mark 10). Jesus also tells us that when we practice loving one another, the world (unbelievers) will know that we are disciples of Jesus, and that Jesus really did come from God, and that God loves them.

Maybe the greatest result is that the world will actually *see God* when we love one another. What an amazing truth! We can show God to a world that desperately needs to see him.

20

No Free Lunch

Whoever wants to be my disciple must deny themselves

and take up their cross daily and follow me.

Luke 9:23

I sincerely believe that God's church in America is the only hope for our country. I believe the church can be that "someone" who builds up the wall and stands in the gap before God. I also believe we need to wake up to the danger of God's judgment upon our complacency over the last fifty years. Where was the church while our country turned its back on God? What was the church doing? Why did we lose the culture wars?

My opinion is that the church in America has been conned by Satan into focusing on ourselves a lot more that we realize. It's not that we aren't good people who work hard and take care of our families and try to live for God. It's rather that we have bought far too much into the radical individualism of our culture, and instead of letting God's kingdom be the most important thing on our priority list, we decide ourselves what's most important. Of course many of the things that are important to us are certainly biblical and right and good, but I fear we've ignored what God says is most important. Jesus said, "Seek first his kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well" (Matthew 6:33). What does this actually look like for us today? What do we need to do to build up the wall? I have a few suggestions.

The first thing we must accept is that this is going to cost us. Jesus said, "Whoever wants to be my disciple must deny themselves and take up their cross daily and follow me" (Luke 9:23). It's most definitely hard to deny ourselves and take orders from someone else, even if it is Jesus. The

cross was God's will for Jesus' life, and as we all know, it was very hard. Our cross is to do and be whatever God wants, even if it's hard. We cannot follow Christ without paying a price. Jesus never said it would be easy. In fact, he went on to say in Luke 14, "And whoever does not carry their cross and follow me cannot be my disciple" (Luke 14:27). This kind of teaching is not what we like to hear. Jesus is actually saying that we are not his disciples if we haven't taken up our cross.

Following Jesus will mean yielding up our time, our money, and our rights. We'll focus in this chapter on our time and our rights, because if God has these two things, yielding him our money is easy.

We'll begin with our time. This is the most difficult, but without God owning our time there's no chance that our rights or our money will ever belong to God. I'm convinced that every American believer should make a commitment to give God three slots of time—one of them daily, and the other two weekly. I think this is so clear in the Scriptures that to not do it is just plain disobedience. When we're faithful in these three, it will lead to more time given to God—which means faithful followers of Jesus will always have less time than everyone else. Remember that God is the one who created time, so he can expand our time so that we'll be able to do all the things he intends for us to do. But first we have to give our time to God.

Every day we need to have time alone with God to read his Word and pray. The example of Jesus in Mark 1:35 should suffice: "Very early in the morning, while it was still dark, Jesus got up, left the house, and went off to a solitary place, where he prayed" (Mark 1:35). Jesus needed to spend time alone with God, so he took the only moments when he wasn't surrounded by crowds—early in the morning. At other times in Jesus' ministry, we see him sending the disciples away so he can go off by himself to pray.

It has always amazed me that the Son of God needed to spend time alone with his Father, while we are for the most part too busy for that. We're so wrapped up in our busy schedules that we don't even see how much we need to spend time alone with God. This isn't something we do to earn brownie points with God; it's something we *need* to do in order serve God and win the battles with the flesh and Satan.

It would appear that David also spent time with God in the morning: "In the morning, Lord, you hear my voice; in the morning I lay my requests before you and wait expectantly" (Psalm 5:3; see also Psalm 143:8). Early morning works best for me, but I don't think it matters to God when we spend time with him; what matters is *that* we spend time with him.

This time should be occupied with Bible reading and focused prayer. Many people use devotional guides for their time with God. These generally have a verse or two and then some thoughts on the truth of those verses. I think these are a good supplement to our own Bible reading and thoughts. The Holy Spirit will speak to us from the Word, so I believe that each of us should go directly to the Word and listen to what God has to say to us. If our only time alone with God consists of a couple of verses and someone else's thoughts on those verses, we aren't going to receive the nourishment our soul needs to live for God.

Our prayers during this time should be a conversation with God about what he's speaking to us from the Word, the truths that we find in the Scripture we read, and how this should affect our thinking and our actions.

In John 17:3 we read that eternal life is knowing Jesus and God. Christianity is a relationship with God. I know that has been said again and again, yet even so there's every indication that the church has forgotten this truth. Relationships require time—time spent listening and talk-

ing. We talk to God primarily through prayer, and we listen to God primarily through his Word.

One would think that the people who say they've trusted in someone who died in their place so they could spend eternity with God would *want* to spend time with that person. Do we have a regular time set aside every day for interaction with God? Many of us say we pray on a regular basis, but I wonder if we mostly pray while we're doing something else, rather than spend uninterrupted time with God.

A recently released "State of the Bible" report from the American Bible Society reported an 11 percent drop in Bible users in our country, a drop which they called "unprecedented." Only 39 percent of Americans classify as regular Bible users, which is defined as "those who use the Bible at least three to four times each year on their own, outside of a church setting." It's a sad commentary that we now define regular Bible use as only three to four times each year outside of church. Only 10 percent of Americans say they read their Bible daily. It would appear that few of us spend much time at all listening to God. Listening is probably the best way to get to know someone, so if we're not spending much time listening to God, how can we expect to know him better so that we love others as we love ourselves?

The State of the Bible report also demonstrates what the American Bible Society describes as a "major decrease in Scripture engagement," which is defined as "consistent interaction with the Bible that shapes people's choices and transforms their relationships with God, self, and others." The estimated number of Scripture-engaged Americans dropped from 64 million in 2021 to 49 million in 2022.[11]

"Most Americans don't know firsthand the overall story of the Bible—because they rarely pick it up," said Scott McConnell, executive director of LifeWay research. "Even among worship attendees, less than half read the Bible daily. The only time most Americans hear from the Bible is when someone else is reading it."[12] These two statements,

one in 2017 and one in 2022, indicate that our interaction with God's Word is declining. Is it any wonder the church has lost most if not all of its influence on our culture?

On the night before his crucifixion, Jesus prayed for his followers these words: "Sanctify them by the truth; your word is truth" (John 17:17). Sanctification is what it means to become more like Jesus, and the Bible is essential to that process. It would therefore seem that few of us today are becoming more like Jesus. The minimum for showing that we love someone is to spend time with them; so if we won't make time for reading God's Word, how can we begin to say we love him with all our heart, soul, and mind? Access to the Word of God is probably easier in America than in any other country of the world. What a privilege! But we forget the widely quoted principle stating that with great privilege comes great responsibility.

The church in America will not be able to make a difference in our culture, and potentially protect us from God's judgment, if we're unwilling to prioritize spending time with God in his Word.

In addition to daily devotions or quiet time or whatever we want to call our time alone with God, we also need to read widely throughout the Bible just so we're familiar with the living Word of God. Since the Bible is the eternal truth from the God who created the universe and sent his Son to die for us, we can never plumb the depths of Holy Scripture, so we should read it over and over again. Why not make it our goal to read through the entire Bible once per year? Modern technology makes it easier than ever to read through or listen through the whole Bible. A Bible app on our smart phone allows us to listen to God's Word while we drive or exercise or clean the house. Short of physical disability, there's no valid reason why a believer in Jesus Christ cannot read through the Bible every year.

When we're reading our Bibles—whether devotionally or just to read—it's important that we ask God to increasingly reveal to us all that he has done for us through Jesus, and how much he loves us. I'm reminded again of this prayer of Paul for the Ephesians:

> I pray that you, being rooted and established in love, may have power, together with all the Lord's holy people, to grasp how wide and long and high and deep is the love of Christ, and to know this love that surpasses knowledge— that you may be filled to the measure of all the fullness of God. (Ephesians 3:17-19)

This is what I was attempting to communicate earlier in discussing the astounding truth that we can call God our Father. The more we grasp what God has done for us through Christ, and how much he loves us, the more we'll want to glorify his name and build his kingdom and obey him in everything he asks of us.

It's my experience that many times when we're reading the Bible, we allow Satan to make us think that we just don't measure up to all those great saints in Scripture. The truth is that they, too, struggled with sin, and trusting God was difficult for them at times just as it is for us. We therefore need to remind ourselves that "there is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1); we rejoice in the forgiveness we have in Christ, and we keep on reading.

I also believe we should all have a time devoted just to prayer—and a specific kind of prayer. I believe it's good that we're praying for the requests from our brothers and sisters in Christ, but as I said, we tend to ignore what Jesus clearly told us to pray for. Also, Paul has given us examples of how to pray for the church. It seems to me that our prayer time should begin with what God has already told us to pray for, and then we can pray for other things.

The church desperately needs to understand and know the amazing truth that God is our Father. I cannot emphasize this enough. Everything else hinges on this, yet we rarely hear anyone pray about this. The rest of the Lord's Prayer will naturally and logically flow from this.

I have Paul's major prayers (from his letters) divided up into six days, and I pray a different one each day of the week for the church everywhere, for the church in America, and for the local church I attend. Then I offer that prayer also for myself and my family. Sundays are reserved for Jesus' prayer for unity from John 17:20-23. Meanwhile I use the Lord's Prayer every day.

Jesus also told us to ask God for workers in the harvest fields—meaning of course more people doing evangelism. Paul also asks for prayer that he might share the gospel effectively (Colossians 4:2-4; Ephesians 6:19). I don't have the gift of evangelism, so I pray this regularly for myself.

These specific suggestions for daily time in God's Word and prayer are only that—suggestions. Everyone has to work out for themselves the approach and practices that work best for them. But if the statistics I've read are true, we Christians need to ramp up big time our meeting alone with God.

These activities probably take me about an hour each day. I cannot imagine how we can stand before the God of the universe and try to explain why we couldn't give him one hour per day—especially if doing so would change the church so that real potential judgment could be staved off.

The excuse I've heard most often for missing out on time alone with God is that we're just so busy. I seriously doubt that any of us is busier than Jesus was when he was on this earth, yet he made time for getting

alone with his Father. God is able to stretch our time, but we have to take a step of faith to see it happen.

The church in America is weak, and I believe one of the main reasons is that we don't spend enough time in the Word building our relationship with God, so that we glorify his name and obey him and tell others about Jesus.

21

We Need Each Other

And let us consider how we may spur one another on

toward love and good deeds, not giving up meeting together,

as some are in the habit of doing, but encouraging one another—

and all the more as you see the Day approaching.

Hebrews 10:24-25

The verses above appear as the third of three exhortations the author of Hebrews gives us in light of the amazing and unique work of Christ to provide forgiveness of sin "once for all" (Hebrews 9:26). All three exhortation are preceded by a summation of the truths given in chapters 9–10. The author of Hebrews is saying, "Because of what I have just written—and just to make sure you've really taken it in—I will summarize." Basically he is saying that because we can call God our Father (because of the work of Christ on our behalf), we need to do these three things:

First, "Draw near to God," which of course means develop and build our relationship with God.

Second, "Hold unswervingly to the hope we profess"—which means we're to never give up on the truths about Jesus we've been taught, even when we don't understand our current circumstances, because Jesus is faithful to us.

The third exhortation is the one we'll focus on in this chapter: "Spur one another on toward love and good deeds," which we obviously cannot do unless we regularly and physically get together with other believers.

These verses from Hebrews 10 are well known, and I remember early in my Christian life hearing people say, "When the doors of the church are open, if you really love God, you'll be there." This meant Sunday school and worship on Sunday morning, and worship on Sunday evening, and Wednesday prayer meeting. These two verses were quoted in support of this position. All these services and ministries were valid and important and had their place.

Times have changed. I believe that we need now to look back to the New Testament church. What did the first church, a mega-church, focus on? In the first six chapters of the book of Acts we get a clear picture of the practices of the New Testament church, which everyone says they want to be like. I've already pointed out that we already are a lot like the New Testament church in that we certainly aren't perfect, and we have major issues to work out. But the New Testament church did some things that today most believers would say are only optional, and I believe this is another major weakness of the church in America today.

I've said that there are three time commitments every believer needs to make in order to effectively grow in Christ and serve Christ. The first is time alone with God every day. The second and third ones involve regular focused time with other believers every week. The church that was led by the apostles of Jesus had two meetings every week. They met for a large group teaching session, most likely in the temple in Jerusalem; then they met in small groups in various homes to remind themselves of what Jesus had done for them on the cross and to discuss the apostolic teaching they'd heard most recently.

The details Luke reports for us in these early chapters of Acts make it clear that the apostles taught every day in the temple courts and in some of the homes where the small groups were meeting (5:42). I believe they did this so everyone had an opportunity to hear the Word

proclaimed. They didn't have any music or special programs—just plain teaching about Jesus being the Messiah and all that this meant.

Today in the typical evangelical church we have a worship and teaching service on Sunday morning that includes some kind of worship music and a message or sermon from the pastor, along with a few announcements thrown in to communicate what's going on in the life of that particular congregation. This is a good thing, and I believe every believer out there should make a commitment to attend this kind of service every week whether we are at home or on the road.

We *need* to be taught the Word for our spiritual health, and we *need* to be with other followers of Jesus while we're being taught. Our brothers and sisters in Christ *need* us to be there. We became "strangers and exiles" (1 Peter 2:11) in this world the moment we first believed, and we now have an enemy that hates us and hates our Savior with a passion, and he'll do anything he can to destroy us and the testimony of Christ. We are now a "new creation" in Christ (2 Corinthians 5:17), and there's a war going on in each of us against the flesh. We need regular teaching about the sovereignty of our Lord and Savior over the circumstances of life, about the greatness of God and his power to help us be victorious in the many battles we face every day. We need to hear regularly about the beyond-astounding and amazing love of God and Christ for us demonstrated in the cross, and about the totally undeserved faithfulness of God to us every day of every week.

Why is it that so many of us think it's basically optional to be part of a body of believers every week—hearing the Word of God proclaimed, and worshiping the one who has done so much for us. I wonder if the reason for this is that Satan wants to keep us in the nose-bleed seats, watching the game on the field that we're supposed to be part of. We don't realize our need because we think we're doing fine and things are going well. Could this be because we aren't even in the game? Satan has

conned us into thinking it's all about us and our comfortable life, and since we're doing fine, all must be well. We don't realize how much our fellow believers need us, and how much we need them, and how we must have spiritual food in order to thrive in a hostile world.

Modern technology has made it possible for many believers to just stay home in their PJ's and watch a Sunday morning service live-streamed—no need to even physically step through the doors at the local church we "attend." We can also catch some of the big name preachers from around the country, and be fed an appealing meal from God's Word. We might even find a service that has the right kind of music that really helps us feel close to God.

It's much like watching a sporting event on TV. We can go to the fridge or the bathroom anytime, or change channels to another preacher if this one isn't doing it for us this week, or even power off the screen entirely if we just aren't interested right now. We don't even have to watch anything on Sunday morning—we can sleep in and catch whatever message we want later in the day or week by going online and listening to a recorded message that's made available.

Again, this thinking shows just how individualistic we've become. It's all about me and my wants, what makes me feel good—all the while ignoring the clear example of Scripture and the needs of other believers. Modern tech is great, and I'm thankful for it, but I believe it's wrong to settle for "attending" church online unless we find it physically impossible to attend a local worship service.

This is the second commitment of time we all need to make—being physically present and participating in a worship and teaching service with other believers. The third commitment of time should be to active and regular participation in a small group of believers who are part of the larger group we worship with every week. I believe this group should focus on the biblical message we all heard at the worship service,

remembering the death of Christ on the cross, praying for the things God has told us to pray for, and encouraging each other to greater and greater love for one another and our neighbors.

I believe that the first thought of many about this commitment will be, "I'm super busy already, when will I have time to do more?" The problem here is that we don't see our need for this kind of meeting. This was well illustrated for me a couple of months ago when the small men's group I participate in had to be canceled due to extremely icy roads that made driving dangerous. Our leader sent out an email stating that he really didn't want to cancel because he needed what this group provided for him every week. The next time we met, he was telling us how much he missed our being together the previous week, because it was this group that helped him fight against sin on a daily basis. This man is a busy, successful businessman who spends a great deal of time preparing to lead our group. He regularly shares with us his struggles to be Christlike in how he conducts himself. He says that this group is what encourages him and challenges him, and that he needs to meet with us every week.

The rest of us in the group need it as well. We have a great time discussing the biblical text for that week, and often part of that discussion involves one or more of us speaking about our victories and defeats in living for Jesus. It's so encouraging to know that I'm not the only one who's less than perfect; it's a joy and privilege to meet with a group of men having different ages, occupations, and family situations, but all sharing a desire to know and serve Jesus. We literally need each other.

I wonder if the reason so many believers are too busy to commit to participating in a small group is that we don't see or feel the need. Scripture tells us that we're in a spiritual war that requires a special kind of armor to be able to stand and win the battles (Ephesians 6:10-17). Peter tells us that Satan is like a "roaring lion seeking someone to devour" (1 Pe-

ter 5:8). Do we feel the battle? Do we long to be away from the fight against sin? Maybe Satan doesn't need to attack many of us because we're so comfortable in those nose-bleed seats that we're no threat to what he's doing.

I know what the first objection to this type of group will be: "Why does it have to focus on the pastor's message we all heard?" First of all, the apostolic teaching done in the New Testament was done by Jesus' apostles. Our source of apostolic teaching is the Bible, the authoritative, inerrant, living Word of God. We need to make sure we're under a teaching ministry that teaches the Bible and believes that Jesus Christ is the only way to heaven. I cannot understand how a believer can be part of and support a supposed church that doesn't believe the Bible is God's Word, and does not submit to its authority. Also, how can they grow spiritually if they aren't being fed spiritual food?

I believe that most Bible-believing pastors, at least those I'm aware of, pray and try to carefully listen to God about what they should be teaching the congregation each week. This means that whatever truth of Scripture they're preaching on each week is what God wants them and us to hear. It's not by chance that we're hearing the message we hear at our worship and teaching services. Therefore, if God has arranged it so that we hear this particular message, why in the world would we not focus on it during our small group meeting? God has this message for us individually and as a group, so we need to pay close attention to what's taught and figure out how it applies to our lives. What better place to do this than in our small group?

I well realize that the Holy Spirit can and does lead a particular group to focus on a different biblical topic or book for a period of time because of particular needs in that group. But most of the time I've heard things like, "We're not interested in this series, so we want to try something else that everyone will like." Or, "One of our group members read

a really great Christian book and we would rather discuss that for a while." I think this just reveals how we're so much about ourselves and not the whole church. Do we actually believe that the sovereign God of the universe knows what's best for us, and that he can and does speak to us through our pastors? It's a proven fact that if we just listen to something we remember little of it. God says he expects us to do much more than just listen to what God is telling us (Matthew 7:24-27). What better way to recall what we heard in Sunday's message, and then to apply it to our lives, than by discussing it with our brothers and sisters in Christ?

When Jesus instituted communion, he told us, "Do this in remembrance of me" (1 Corinthians 11:24-25). The early church did this in their small groups, probably because that was the only way they could actually do it. Most churches today that I'm aware of celebrate communion as an entire congregation, which is certainly a good thing. Why not do both? In our small group as well as in our worship service, would it be wrong to be reminded of what Jesus did for us? Obviously no. We've celebrated communion in our small groups, and it has been well received. I would encourage all of us to give it a try.

I've already spent a great deal of time on how I believe we need to change the things we pray for, so I won't pound that drum anymore. I would suggest, though, that we actually spend more time praying than we do sharing what to pray for. I would also encourage us to remind ourselves regularly what Jesus told us to pray for, and the example of Paul. I would also encourage us to not pray "preacher prayers"—long-winded prayers in which one person covers everything they can think of, and the rest of us are wondering when they're going to quit. Preacher prayers are great when it's just God and me, but in a group it's much like listening to a lecture.

All of these time commitments must result in changed lives. Religious activity that doesn't create humble holiness and a sincere love for one another and our neighbors is just a waste of time.

I said earlier that these three time commitments would result in further time given over to God. How could they not? The more we understand and grasp the great love God has for us, and what it cost him and his Son to make that happen, and the more we see how God is at work in others' lives, the more we'll want to serve God by serving others.

Notice that the church in Acts ended up with many of the people selling some of their possessions and assets— "And God's grace was so powerfully at work in them all that there were no needy persons among them" (Acts 4:34). It will actually cause us to pray and ask God to show us opportunities to serve our brothers and sisters in Christ, as well as our neighbors. God definitely will answer these kinds of prayers, which will mean more time serving others. This would then show America a church that's truly about glorifying God and serving others instead of serving ourselves. This is the kind of thing that changes the culture.

I think it's important to remind ourselves of God's promises—that if we humbly put his kingdom and his righteousness ahead of ourselves, he will take care of everything else and exalt us. But the only way we're going to see this happen is to take steps of faith by making Jesus Lord of our time and priorities.

22

Will We Build the Wall?

I looked for someone among them who would build up the wall

and stand before me in the gap on behalf of the land

so I would not have to destroy it, but I found no one.

Ezekiel 22:30

What makes me most nervous in the verse above is the part about having to "destroy" the land. A nation can reach a point when God—because of who he is—must judge and destroy them. There's no turning back, which is what the circumstances were when Amos prophesied. God was finished reaching out; his justice and holiness now demanded that he judge his people. The word "destroy" should make us nervous—as we read in the Old Testament prophets, when God "destroys" something, it's not at all pretty.

The second phrase that scares me is this: "But I found no one." All God needed was one man, who would stand up before him so he wouldn't have to destroy the land. One man like Moses who stood before God and reminded him that God's reputation was on the line. One man who understands that God's glory is paramount and will pray in such a way that God changes his mind and decides not to wipe out his people. But no one came out of the stands to take the field, so the game was ended. I hope the game isn't over for America.

Again I must emphasize that I'm not a prophet like the Old Testament prophets, and I'm not claiming that I've heard from God. But I've tried to point out some things that should make us nervous, and I wonder if we (the church) need to pay attention and step up and plug the hole. A brief summary of why we should be nervous might be helpful.

The first reason I'm concerned is that in reading the Old Testament prophets and their warnings to Israel and Judah, I found far too many similarities with our country today. God actually held his people to a higher standard because they had the Law and the Prophets, so when they just ignored God's clear teaching and refused to pay attention—no matter what God did to get their attention—he had to judge them. He clearly didn't want to, but he had to. He clearly had told them exactly what would happen if they didn't follow him (Deuteronomy 28), and they knew it—but they refused to listen, so God hammered them. We (America) are not God's chosen people like the Jews, so if he judged them so severely, why would he not judge us?

The second reason I'm concerned is that God has been so good to us as a nation. Most of the Christians I know have no problem saying that God has really blessed this country. I would agree. How would we feel if we'd done really nice things for someone and they not only failed to thank us, but they gave us the finger and turned their back on us? We would be justifiably furious. Now I know that God is much greater than we are, but even he has his limits. I just hope he hasn't reached them.

The third reason I'm concerned is that we really do deserve his judgment. Our leaders have proudly endorsed and promoted things that God says are evil and bad, and they're not little things either. Every one of the three things I wrote about earlier: no-fault divorce, abortion, and the LGBTQ agenda are things that God says are really offensive to him. Not only that, but many of these same leaders in our country proclaim that they're good Christians. Just like in the days of Jeroboam II and the Northern Kingdom (Israel), many of our leaders say they're following God, yet all the while they're promoting what God says is evil, and they're calling it good. This is not enough though; so to cover their bases, they're idolaters too. Now, America's idols aren't made of wood and stone like Israel's were. This at least would be acknowledging there's a greater god that we have to answer to. No, our idol is *us*. We worship

at the idol of man. We've become a narcissistic culture that worships at the altar of self. We decide what's right and what's wrong. We decide what's good for us. We have the power. This self-centeredness and arrogant pride of our culture have to be repulsive to God.

I've heard it said, "If God doesn't judge America, he owes Sodom and Gomorrah an apology." The people who say this are Bible-believing Christians. First and foremost, God owes absolutely no one an apology for anything he has done ever. Second, why are we who see this not doing something about it?

I believe we can, and I hope we will.

23

Will We Stand in the Gap?

They replied, "Let us start rebuilding."

So they began this good work.

Nehemiah 2:18

In Nehemiah 2, Jerusalem's people responded positively after receiving Nehemiah's assessment of the condition of God's people in God's city—even as Nehemiah recognized their "disgrace" (Nehemiah 1:7).

Disgrace. Is God's church a disgrace in America? Are we that bad?

Our immediate reaction could well be, "No way!" But as I've pointed out, we live in a completely self-centered, narcissistic culture, and I truly believe we've been influenced by our culture way too much. The proof of this seems to be the awful moral condition of America. What were we doing to allow this to happen? Could it be that we've been just as self-focused as the culture at large?

Is there anything we can do? I believe there is—and that we certainly can once again influence our culture through the power of Christ-centered living that denies self by giving up our rights and lives to glorify God through building his kingdom by evangelism and by loving our brothers and sisters in Christ, and loving our neighbors above ourselves.

Prayer that's both humble and bold is where we must begin. The humility comes in as we admit that we as Americans have sinned against God, and we deserve his judgment. Then, like Daniel, Ezra, and Nehemiah, we should be able to admit that we, the church, have sinned

against God as well. We can ask God to show us just how self-centered we've become, both individually and as a church.

Three passages of Scripture are helpful to me on this; I mentioned all three earlier, and they're worth revisiting.

In Psalm 139:23-24, David is asking God to show him "if there is any offensive way in me." Am I loving my fellow believers as much as I love myself? Am I loving my neighbor as much as I love myself?

Hebrews 3:13 tell us that all believers need exhortation "every day" so that we aren't hardened by the deceitfulness of sin. Sin cons us, so that we don't see ourselves as objectively as we should. How have we been conned by self-centeredness? Is it true that we've become as self-focused as the culture around us, while Satan has us believing we actually aren't that bad? Have we been hardened to the point of even refusing to even ask the question?

Have we given another person in our life permission to be honest with us about sin that we may not be aware of, or sin that we aren't dealing with? Can we admit that because God says we need this kind of exhortation every day, we probably aren't doing as well as we think, since the evidence would seem to show that most American Christians consider regular participation in worship and teaching services and a small group to be optional?

In Psalm 19, David acknowledges, "Who can discern their own errors?" Then he prays:

> Forgive my hidden faults. Keep your servant also from willful sins; may they not rule over me. Then I will be blameless, innocent of great transgression. May these words of my mouth and this meditation of my heart be pleasing in your sight, Lord, my Rock and my Redeemer. (Psalm 19:12-14)

Are we humble enough to admit that we're sinning against God in ways we don't even realize? The really humbling thing about this is that in Christ, God has already forgiven even those sins which we're committing but are unaware of. Just because we're unaware doesn't make them less offensive to God, yet he remains faithful. Should this not make us want to please him even more, and to find out what more we need to do in order to live that way?

Throughout this book I've been asking questions that we, the church, need to ask. Will we ask them? Will we humble ourselves before God? God responds to a humble heart. As David says, "My sacrifice, O God, is a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart you, God, will not despise" (Psalm 51:17).

Sometimes when we become aware of the magnitude of our sin, we feel that we cannot ask God for anything. I believe Satan would have us believe this, because while it seems so spiritual to beat ourselves up because we've failed, in actuality we're once again being self-centered as we focus on how bad we are.

The truth is, we have been forgiven! We are sons and daughters of God! He loves us more than we can ever imagine! We can own up to our sin, thank God for his forgiveness, and press on and join the battle. We can confidently come to God and pray with a holy boldness the kinds of prayers that we know God wants to answer, because he told us what to pray for and gave us examples of what to pray for.

God wants us to understand what a great privilege it is that we can call him our Father. He wants us to glorify his great name. He wants us to build his kingdom and obey him.

We can be like Moses and remind God that we are his church, his Son's bride, and that while we've done a poor job of honoring him, his name is tied to us irrevocably—so we ask him to please change us so the world

can see clearly how great he is, and just maybe enough of those who see will repent and come to know him as we do, and God won't have to destroy our land.

We can even go one step further and humbly mention to God that America has for a long time been seen by much of the rest of the world as a Christian country, and then ask God to please change our country so instead of flipping him off, we honor and respect the values represented in our Judeo-Christian heritage.

As I stated earlier, I believe we're already experiencing God's wrath, so I also pray Habakkuk 3:2 for our country: "Lord, I have heard of your fame; I stand in awe of your deeds, Lord. Repeat them in our day, in our time make them known; in wrath remember mercy" (Habakkuk 3:2).

Now that we've prayed, it's time to take concrete steps to demonstrate that we're truly repentant. We need to be committed to being a participant and not just a spectator in our local church. For some of us, this will mean that we actually attend instead of watch online. We need to believe that our pastor is preaching and teaching the texts of Scripture that God wants us to hear, and therefore God wants us to do something about what we hear. We need to find or maybe start a small Bible study group and make it a priority to be there and participate.

Many of us already have some brothers and sisters in Christ we need to bear with instead of avoid; we may need to forgive them as Christ forgave us. All of us will certainly have to do this at some point in the future, if we actually obey God and are involved in our local church.

Jesus told two parables at the end of the Olivet Discourse in Matthew 24 that we can use to examine ourselves as to whether or not we're doing everything God wants us to be doing.

In Matthew 24:45-51, Jesus tells of a master who has left one of the servants in charge of the household while the master is gone. Here's the

question Jesus wants us to ask ourselves: When the Master returns, will he find his servant taking care of the Master's household? Or will he find the servant ignoring the Master's priorities and doing whatever the servant feels like doing?

In the next chapter of Matthew, Jesus tells another parable, this one about a man who leaves on a trip and gives assets to his servants, based on their ability, and expects them to use those assets to make this man richer. Two of the three servants are careful to invest what their master left them and make more money for him. The third guy just sat on it and did nothing with what his master entrusted him with (25:14-30). God has created us with natural talents and abilities, and when we believed, we were given us spiritual gifts. God has the reasonable expectation that we'll use these assets to build his kingdom and make him look good. A small group is a great place to talk about how we can better love one another and love our neighbor as we love ourselves. Since this is assuredly the greatest return on investment in God's kingdom, we should start to make some significant deposits into these two stocks.

Nehemiah's challenge to the people of Jerusalem was accepted and acted upon. The whole city was involved in rebuilding the wall to remove the shame from Jerusalem. Likewise the whole church needs to be involved in restoring God's glory and honor in our midst. In Nehemiah 4:1 we read, "The people worked with all their heart." The work was hard, and often it seemed hopeless (4:10). There was life-threatening opposition (2:19; 4:1-3; 11-12; 6:1-13), but Nehemiah challenged the people: "Don't be afraid of them. Remember the Lord, who is great and awesome, and fight for your families, your sons and your daughters, your wives and your homes" (4:14). The wall wasn't rebuilt overnight, but the people did accomplish what no one thought was possible, except perhaps Nehemiah. The entire wall was rebuilt in fifty-two days (6:15).

Our God is as great and awesome now as he was in Nehemiah's day. And he is still gracious and compassionate, wanting much rather to forgive and to bless than to judge.

I certainly don't know if God is going to judge our country, but it seems to me that if there's even a chance of God judging us—and if we realize how good we have it here in America, and if we love our children and grandchildren—we should be willing to pay whatever cost it may require to prevent that judgment from happening.

24

Carrying Our Cross

Whoever wants to be my disciple must

deny themselves and take up their

cross daily and follow me.

Luke 9:23

About forty years ago, I preached through the book of Amos and came to the conclusion that our country was in grave danger of being judged by God. So what did I do about it?

Nothing! I was a pastor, so I was in the Word on a daily basis with my devotions, reading through the Bible every year, plus study time for sermons and Bible studies, and I prayed and was leading small groups. But I certainly was not building the wall or standing in the gap on behalf of our country. I was not broken by the sin of our country, and my prayers mostly reflected my own priorities rather than God's glory.

I fear that way too many Bible-believing Christians are just like I was. We know there's a big problem, but what can we do about it?

I've made several specific suggestions in this book about what we can do. Many of us will agree that there's real danger, and that yes, we should do something. But my fear is that you'll think what I am asking will take too much of your time—focused time alone with God every day to actually pray for the things Jesus told us to pray for, plus gathering with like-minded believers each week for Sunday worship and for Bible study group.

But please remember: Jesus never said following him would be easy or convenient, and if we aren't willing to pay the price, maybe we're not even his disciples.

Also, Jesus promises that if we actually put him and his kingdom and righteousness ahead of our own stuff, he will honor and bless that (Matthew 6:33).

If we really believe that our country is in serious danger of God's judgment, and that his judgment is as awful as the Bible depicts it—why wouldn't we do everything in our power, no matter how it affects our time, to prevent this?

It took me a long while to realize that I had to radically change what I pray for. I had read and studied what the Bible taught about prayer, and I had read the actual prayers prayed by Jesus and others in the Bible. Somehow, I missed what really impresses God. Jesus very clearly tells us (in the Lord's Prayer) that God's name being made great and special is the first thing we should be praying about most. Jesus told us that God wants to say yes to this—and yet for me it took years to figure that out.

The way I pray has been changed by the example of Moses standing boldly before the God of the universe, who had told Moses to get out of the way so he could destroy the Israelites; Moses reminded God of his glory, and he saw God change his mind.

At the very minimum, can we all get before God daily and ask him to glorify his name in and through our lives and through his church?

He wants to say yes to this! Imagine what the church will look like when God says yes to this prayer.

Notes

[1] Leon Morris, *The Apostolic Preaching of the Cross*, 200.

[2] "The Evolution of Divorce," *National Affairs*, Number 54, Winter 2023.

[3] "The Evolution of Divorce."

[4] https://news.gallup.com/poll/393197/same-sex-marriage-support-inches-new-high.aspx.

[5] Robert A. J. Gagnon, *The Bible and Homosexual Practice: Text and Hermeneutics*, 37.

[6] Gagnon, *The Bible and Homosexual Practice*, 122.

[7] Gagnon, *The Bible and Homosexual Practice*, 71-78.

[8] Larry Osborne, *Thriving in Babylon*, 136.

[9] Constantine R. Campbell, *Jesus v. Evangelicals: A Biblical Critique of a Wayward Movement*, 37.

[10] Campbell, *Jesus v. Evangelicals*, 37.

[11] *The Christian Post*, April 7, 2022.

[12] *The Courier,* April 25, 2017.



About the Author

Eric Wait is a retired pastor with decades of experience shepherding communities and teaching the Word. After years of ministry, Eric felt a growing urgency to speak into the cultural and spiritual challenges facing Christians today.

That calling led to *A Concerned Christian* — a podcast where Eric brings a thoughtful, pastoral voice to the conversations that matter most. His hope is to encourage believers to think deeply, live faithfully, and hold fast to the truth of Scripture.

Read more at https://aconcernedchristian.net/.